International Trade Centre

Funded by the European Union

Timor-Leste | Digital Presence & Positioning Assessment

Draft: Thursday, March 26, 2026

Table of Contents

Executive Summary **5**

1. Framing the Digital Presence and Positioning Assessment 7
    1.1 Purpose and Scope of the Digital Presence Assessment 7
    1.2 Assessment Framework: Journey, Segments, and Evidence 8
2. Official Tourism Website Audit 9
    2.1 Overall Technical Health 12
    2.2 Performance and User Experience (Desktop vs Mobile) 13
    2.3 Core Web Vitals and Technical Quality Signals 13
    2.4 What This Means for Timor-Leste's Digital Readiness 15
3. Digital Storytelling & Content Gaps 16
    3.1 Destination Narrative & Visual Identity 16
    3.2 Journey-Stage Content Gaps 19
    3.3 Content Gaps by Traveler Segment 22
    3.4 Structural Diagnosis Summary 24
4. Comparative Benchmark of Reference Tourism Websites 26
    4.1 Planning Architecture & Content Packaging Differences 27
    4.2 Comparative Conversion Infrastructure 34
    4.3 Competitive Positioning Implications 35
5. Tour Operator Representation and Product Listing Quality 36
    5.1 Analytical Scope 37
    5.2 Representation Quality Framework 38
    5.3 Thematic Positioning Patterns in Operator Portfolios 39
    5.4 Strategic Relevance for Timor-Leste 40
    5.5 Market Readiness & Positioning Implications 41
6. Destination Perception Mapping 42
    6.1 Persona Snapshot Overview #1: Adventure, Eco-Exploration, Nature & Solo Traveler 43
    6.2 Persona Snapshot Overview #2: Marine, Diving, Sailing & Yachting Traveler 44
    6.3 Persona Snapshot Overview #3: Cultural, Experiential & Couple-Oriented Travelers 46
    6.4 Persona Snapshot Overview #4: Backpackers & Budget-Oriented Independent Travelers 48
    6.5 What the Four Persona Journeys Reveal 50
7. Conclusion 50

Glossary of Key Terms 55

Annex A - Tour Operator Representation Scoring Framework 58

Annex B - Website Performance Diagnostics & Priority Optimisation Actions 61

Annex C - Tour Operator Content Analysis Methodology and Scoring Framework 65

Annex D - Thematic Analysis Keyword Definitions 70

Annex E – Visitor Personas & Journey Maps 72

Acronyms

AVIF – AV1 Image File Format

CLS – Cumulative Layout Shift

CMS – Content Management System

CSS – Cascading Style Sheets

CTA – Call to Action

FCP – First Contentful Paint

INP – Interaction to Next Paint

LCP – Largest Contentful Paint

PNG – Papua New Guinea

QA – Quality Assurance

SEO – Search Engine Optimization

TBT – Total Blocking Time

UGC – User-Generated Content

WebP – Web Picture format

XML – Extensible Markup Language

Executive Summary

This report assesses whether Timor-Leste's current digital presence is structurally equipped to convert international interest into structured trip planning and confirmed visitation.

The previous assessment on Destination Visibility and Reputation identified emerging niche demand — particularly in marine and eco-nature segments — while confirming that overall global awareness remains limited. In this context, the digital ecosystem plays a dual role: it must build awareness while also reducing uncertainty at the planning stage. This report evaluates whether that conversion function is currently being fulfilled.

Destination Visibility and Reputation — Key Findings Recap

Timor-Leste has niche-validated appeal in marine, eco-nature, and cultural segments, but limited mainstream global awareness. Discovery occurs primarily through specialist channels (dive operators, eco-travel media, independent platforms) rather than broad organic search. Perception quality is high within niche circles, but not present in mainstream consideration. These findings establish the baseline against which this report evaluates digital preparedness.

Technical Foundation

The official tourism website rests on a sound technical base. It is crawlable, indexed, and logically structured around thematic categories such as destinations, experiences, and practical planning information. There is no evidence of systemic platform failure or architectural instability. The technical issues identified are primarily refinement and governance-related: slower mobile performance for image-heavy pages, template rendering inconsistencies in certain directory and listing pages, and minor structural inconsistencies. These are optimization challenges rather than redesign requirements.

What's Working: Awareness and Interest

International media coverage, influencer storytelling, review sentiment, and specialist tour operator listings generate interest in Timor-Leste that is grounded in authenticity, remoteness, marine biodiversity, and cultural depth. However, as travelers move from inspiration into researching and comparison, structural constraints become more visible.

Where Gaps Emerge: Planning and Conversion

Information exists across the official website and third-party channels, but it is not consistently organized into a clear planning spine. Itinerary structures are present but unevenly packaged. Thematic assets — marine, cultural, highland, and coastal experiences — are well described individually but not consistently consolidated into structured route logic. Internal linking between activities, itineraries, operators, and practical logistics is present but inconsistent.

The result is friction. Conversion occurs — particularly among high-motivation segments such as marine and adventure travelers — but often despite structural fragmentation rather than because of clearly sequenced digital progression.

Comparative Benchmark & Operator Representation

Comparative benchmarking reinforces this diagnosis. Reference destinations in the region do not necessarily possess stronger narrative differentiation, but they package planning pathways more clearly. Structured "Plan Your Trip" hubs, consistent itinerary scaffolding, visible enquiry prompts, and standardized event formatting reduce uncertainty earlier in the decision journey. The competitive gap is therefore not content volume or brand strength, but journey reliability.

International tour operator representation confirms baseline market readiness. Timor-Leste is actively sold through scheduled departures and recognizable 6–10 day circuits, signaling operational confidence. Cultural and marine themes dominate, while inland biodiversity, wildlife, food, and Portuguese heritage remain secondary narratives. Expectation-setting around logistics and pacing is uneven.

Pattern Across All Segments

Across all four analyzed traveler personas, a consistent structural pattern emerges: awareness strength exceeds planning coherence. The constraint is not narrative weakness or absence of product. It is connective fragility — the translation of appeal into structured, confidence-building trip design.

The destination's appeal is not in question, but the digital scaffolding needed to convert interest into bookings requires targeted reinforcement.

Key Findings at a Glance:

(1) The official website's technical foundation is stable — the priority is optimization, not reconstruction.

(2) Timor-Leste performs well at the Awareness stage through niche channels, but conversion architecture is weak at the Researching and Booking stages.

(3) Comparator destinations demonstrate achievable, low-cost improvements in planning depth and itinerary packaging.

(4) All four priority traveler segments face friction at the Researching stage.

1. Framing the Digital Presence and Positioning Assessment

1.1 Purpose and Scope of the Digital Presence Assessment

Timor-Leste is currently discovered primarily through specialist and niche channels — dive operators, eco-travel publishers, and independent travel platforms — rather than through mainstream organic search. Mainstream visibility remains limited. This report assesses whether the destination's digital infrastructure can convert that niche-level awareness into structured trip planning and confirmed bookings.

The previous report on **Destination Visibility and Reputation Assessment** asked: *How is Timor-Leste seen?* This assessment now asks: I*s the destination digitally prepared and positioned to convert that attention into action*?

In practical terms, digital preparedness would mean:

- Clear, consistent itineraries that answer "How many days do I need?"
- Structured activity pages that explain where, when, and how experiences take place
- Reliable directories and operator listings without technical errors
- Visible next steps for inquiry or booking
- Consistent messaging between official channels and international tour operators

This assessment examines whether official platforms and third-party representations provide that level of clarity and reliability across the traveler journey, from awareness to research to booking.

It does not evaluate physical infrastructure, macro-level tourism policy, or branding. Instead, it focuses specifically on digital usability, content coherence, structural clarity, and operator representation.

1.2 Assessment Framework: Journey, Segments, and Evidence

This assessment continues with the same conceptual structure of the Digital Travel Journey. This framework follows how travel demand forms and progresses in digital environments.

Figure 1.2: Digital Travel Journey Example



The Digital Travel Journey maps the stages through which a traveler moves — from first hearing about a destination (Awareness) to actively researching it (Exploration), building a trip (Researching and Planning), and committing to a booking (Booking and Validation). At each stage, travelers need different things from a destination's digital presence. This framework is used throughout the report to identify where Timor-Leste's digital channels support progression and where structural gaps interrupt it.

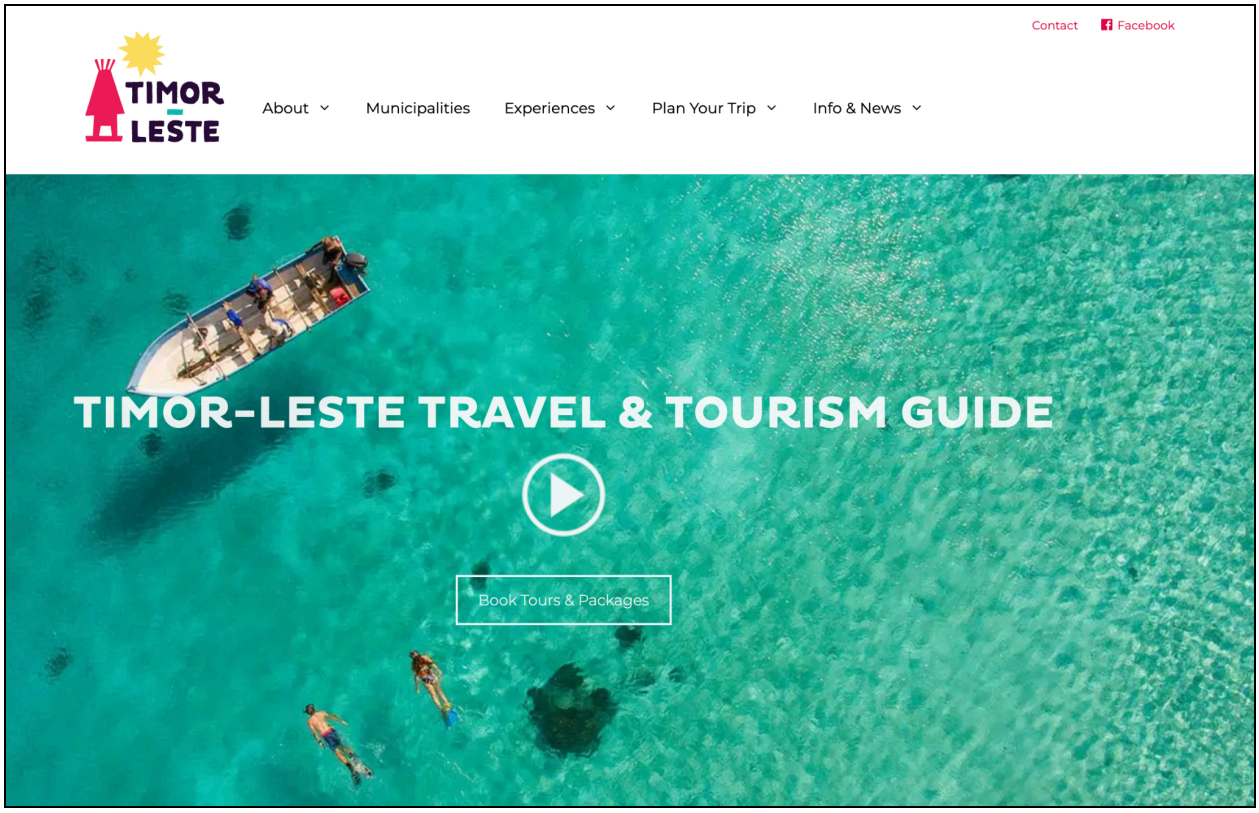
In this assessment, it is used to evaluate whether Timor-Leste's digital ecosystem supports progression between stages. The analysis tests whether official content (via timorleste.tl) and third-party representations (including international tour operator listings) provide clarity, reassurance, and structure travelers necessary for developing a trip once initial interest is established.

Using a consistent journey framework, traveler segments, and regional benchmarks ensures this assessment functions as the digital readiness counterpart to the previous report's demand-focused analysis.

2. Official Tourism Website Audit

The official tourism website (timorleste.tl) functions as the central digital reference point for the destination. It presents core information on experiences, itineraries, transport, accommodation, safety guidance, events, and certified operators. For international visitors, it serves as one of the highest ranking digital sources of information and practical orientation. For tourism professionals, it acts as a reference tool for validating routes, products, and institutional positioning.

Figure 2 - Timor Leste Tourism Website Homepage



While media, search engines, and tour operators often create initial awareness, the official site plays a different role: it should provide reliable, up-to-date, and structured information that supports planning and confidence. It may not function as a commercial booking engine, but it should reduce uncertainty and clarify next steps.

This audit evaluates whether the current website fulfills that role effectively, particularly for international users and mobile visitors. The assessment is based on publicly accessible content and observable functionality at the time of review. Where technical data or backend analytics were not available, findings are limited to visible user experience and structural signals.

Full performance testing results, including Core Web Vitals benchmarks and technical recommendations, are presented in Annex B.

The focus is not abstract technical compliance, but whether the site reliably supports movement from inspiration to practical planning.

Methodological Approach

The website audit is structured around three diagnostic lenses: usability and information architecture, content depth and relevance, and SEO performance and discoverability. Each lens corresponds to a critical function the website must perform within the traveler decision journey.

These lenses are grounded in established frameworks from web development practice and digital communication analysis. Their selection reflects both general standards for evaluating digital channels and the specific information needs of travelers at each stage of the decision process:

- **Usability and information architecture** is assessed against widely adopted principles of interface design. In a tourism context, this lens determines whether a prospective traveler can navigate from initial curiosity to itinerary planning without confusion or abandonment. It maps directly to the Exploration stage of the Digital Travel Journey.
- **Content depth and relevance** draws on content strategy practice and UNWTO guidance on digital destination marketing. For an emerging destination with limited organic media coverage, the official website substitutes for the richer media ecosystem that surrounds better-known destinations. Content gaps are a structural barrier at the Researching and Planning stage, where travelers form — or abandon — booking intent based on the quality and specificity of information available.
- **SEO performance and discoverability** is measured against Google's published quality guidance (e.g. Search Quality Evaluator Guidelines, Core Web Vitals) and standard search analytics practice. For destinations with low international brand recognition, organic search visibility is often the primary channel through which travelers first encounter the destination, as there are not many competing digital resources. This lens is therefore most consequential at the Awareness stage.

Detailed assessment criteria, scoring logic, and procedural guidance are documented in **Annex B** (Website Performance Diagnostics) and Annex C (Tour Operator Content Analysis Methodology). The website audit covered timorleste.tl; the operator analysis covered international tour operator listings active at the time of review.

Table 2 below summarizes how each stage of the Digital Travel Journey maps to a specific website function, and what failure at each stage looks like in practice.

Table 2 - How Website Performance Affects Each Stage of the Traveler Journey

Journey Stage	Website Function	When It Works Well	When It Fails
Awareness	SEO visibility, homepage clarity, page speed	Destination is easily found in search and quickly understood	Site is hard to find, slow, or unclear about what the destination offers
Exploration	Navigation structure, activity pages, internal links	Users can move easily between themes (e.g. diving, culture, hiking) and see how they connect	Users must guess where to click next; themes feel isolated or repetitive

Researching / Planning	Itineraries, practical information, structured content	Travelers understand how many days they need, where experiences are located, and how to combine them	Duration mismatches, scattered information, or unclear sequencing create doubt
Booking / Validation	Operator listings, directories, inquiry pathways	Clear contact details, consistent formatting, reliable templates build confidence	Technical errors, incomplete listings, or broken forms reduce trust at the decision point
Experience / On-ground confidence	Arrival guidance, transport tips, safety information	Visitors feel prepared and informed before arrival	Missing or fragmented guidance increases anxiety and reliance on third parties

The methodological approach evaluates usability, content structure, SEO visibility, and presentation quality according to how they support—or weaken—these five stages. The goal is not technical perfection, but functional readiness at the moments that influence traveler decisions.

This assessment is based on a manual review of key pages and navigation paths, use of free or widely accessible diagnostic tools, and a comparison against traveler needs and intent patterns identified earlier in the assessment.

2.1 Overall Technical Health

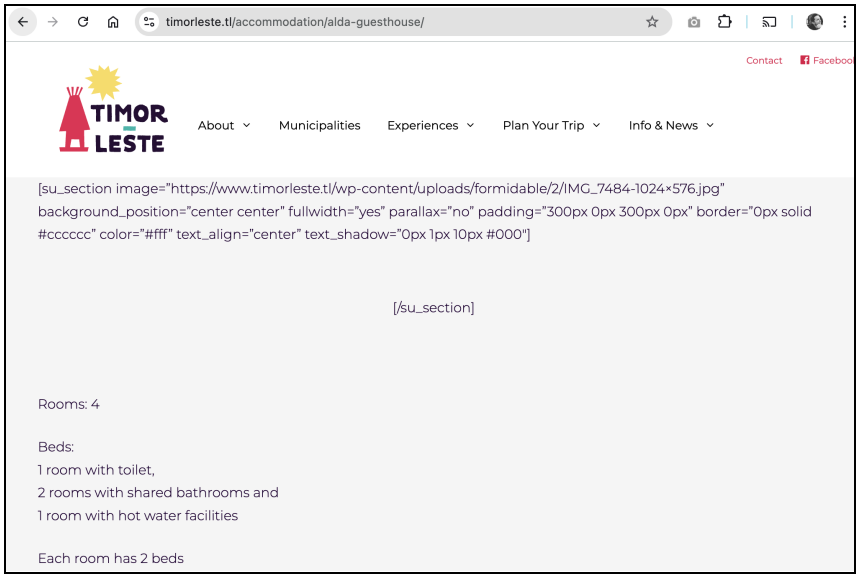
From a structural perspective, the official tourism website is well maintained.

A full crawl of the site found no evidence of widespread technical degradation. Pages load consistently, internal navigation functions as expected, and there are no signs of fully broken pages. This level of baseline reliability is notable for a public-sector destination website and provides a solid foundation for future content and marketing efforts.

Across **268 pages reviewed**, only **eight broken or unreachable links** were identified. This represents a very low error rate and indicates good editorial discipline and ongoing upkeep. Importantly, none of the issues identified affect core navigation, trip planning content, or user journeys.

The broken links fall into predictable and low-risk categories, including external organizations that have changed or removed pages over time, minor domain or URL inconsistencies, and non-essential links to third-party commercial sites.

Figure 3 - Example of Accommodation Director Page Issue



One issue that is present affects all of the individual accommodation and directory pages displaying raw shortcode text (e.g., [su_section …]) instead of formatted content. In these cases, intended images, layout elements, or structured information are not rendering correctly. This is seen on dozens of listing pages.

As a result, while the site remains accessible, parts of the planning and booking layer appear incomplete or technically broken to users. These issues occur at decision points—where travelers are evaluating accommodation or operators—and therefore have a disproportionate impact on trust and confidence.

The overall condition can therefore be described as structurally stable, but with visible presentation defects in key templates that should be treated as a priority fix.

2.2 Performance and User Experience (Desktop vs Mobile)

Mobile performance is particularly important in tourism. Globally, more than half of web traffic now occurs on mobile devices, and travel research is frequently conducted on smartphones, especially during early-stage searching, social media discovery, and link sharing. In many emerging markets, mobile is the primary access point to the internet.

Performance testing using Google PageSpeed Insights indicates a clear divergence between desktop and mobile experience on the official tourism website, based on Core Web Vitals and loading performance indicators.

On desktop devices, the site performs well. Pages load quickly, core content appears promptly, and navigation responds smoothly. This suggests that the underlying hosting environment and infrastructure are stable.

On mobile devices, performance is more constrained. Large images and hero banners at the top of pages take longer to load, and some layout elements shift position as the page renders. This can create a perception that the page is unstable during the first few seconds of use.

Technically, this pattern is consistent with:

- large above-the-fold images that are not fully optimized for mobile delivery
- scripts or stylesheets that delay the first visible content
- insufficient prioritization of the most important elements for slower mobile connections

These delays do not block access to content. However, research shows that perceived slowness affects user exploration behavior. For first-time visitors—particularly those arriving from search engines, media coverage, or social sharing—a slow-loading mobile page can reduce confidence and shorten session length, even if the information itself is strong.

2.3 Core Web Vitals and Technical Quality Signals

Core Web Vitals provide standardized performance indicators used by search engines to evaluate page experience, particularly on mobile devices. These metrics assess loading performance, visual stability, and interaction responsiveness.

For the Timor-Leste tourism website, interaction-related metrics perform well. Once content is visible, navigation and scrolling are smooth, indicating that the site is not burdened by heavy interaction-blocking scripts.

The primary signals of concern relate to early-stage rendering:

- **Largest Contentful Paint (LCP)** on mobile exceeds recommended thresholds, meaning the main visual element loads later than optimal.
- **Cumulative Layout Shift (CLS)** is elevated on certain templates, indicating that page elements move during load due to unreserved image space or dynamic components.

While these issues are technical rather than structural, they influence both user perception and search visibility. Search engines increasingly factor page experience signals into ranking and crawl prioritization.

Sitemap and Technical Governance

The site's XML sitemap reflects a generally logical structure, covering key content categories. However, several technical hygiene issues were observed:

- Many pages show outdated "last modified" timestamps (some from 2020).
- The sitemap appears tool-generated rather than dynamically maintained through the CMS.
- Duplicate URL variants (e.g., trailing slash differences) and filter-based parameter pages are included.

These do not block indexing, but they can dilute crawl efficiency and reduce freshness signals.

Overall, the site's technical profile is stable but would benefit from targeted optimization and improved search governance rather than platform overhaul.

Access to Performance and Search Data

This assessment relies on publicly observable signals. Direct access to Google Search Console and analytics would allow validation of real-user search queries, crawl patterns, and mobile usability warnings. Where such data becomes available, findings can be refined and prioritized based on measured impact.

Key Takeaway — Website Technical Health: The official website provides a stable but unevenly optimized foundation. Technical issues (mobile performance gaps, pages displaying code or not displaying photos) are not structural and can be resolved without platform rebuilding.

2.4 What This Means for Timor-Leste's Digital Readiness

Overall, the official tourism website rests on a stable technical foundation. The site is crawlable, indexed, and structurally organized around clear thematic sections (destinations, experiences, planning information, and listings). There is no evidence of systemic platform failure or architectural instability. As such, timorleste.tl is suitable to function as the central, authoritative digital reference point for the destination.

However, the external crawl and technical review highlight optimization gaps that affect confidence and competitiveness. These include slower mobile loading of large visual elements, visible template rendering defects on some listing pages, inconsistent canonical URL handling (e.g., duplicate variants), and sitemap governance issues such as outdated "last modified" signals. Importantly, these are refinement issues, not structural flaws. They can be addressed through targeted technical adjustments rather than a redesign or platform replacement.

From a visitor journey perspective, the site is unevenly supported by its current technical health:

- **Awareness (Dreaming):** Structurally strong. Core pages are indexed and branded queries return the official site prominently. Mobile performance optimization would strengthen first impressions, particularly for image-led pages.
- **Researching (Evaluation & Planning):** Moderately supported. The architecture is logical, but sitemap hygiene, internal linking discipline, and template reliability affect search competitiveness and clarity at comparison moments.
- **Booking:** Most vulnerable. Template defects on accommodation and listing pages occur at high-intent decision points, which can undermine trust even when content exists.

- **Experience:** Strong in principle. Practical guidance pages are accessible and stable; improving mobile speed will enhance usability for travelers already in-country.
- **Sharing (Post-Visit Advocacy):** Structurally possible, but freshness and structured data enhancements would increase discoverability of events and stories.

Strategically, this means Timor-Leste does not require digital reconstruction. The priority is optimization: improving mobile performance, correcting template defects, strengthening search governance, and consolidating technical consistency. These targeted interventions will increase reliability at key decision moments and better align the site's technical performance with its strong narrative positioning. Detailed diagnostics are provided in Annex B.

3. Digital Storytelling & Content Gaps

This section examines how existing content supports (or limits) trip planning. The focus is not on content volume, but on how clearly information is structured and connected to help users build a trip.

It determines whether a traveler can move from "This place interests me" to "I understand how to visit." In emerging destinations especially, storytelling must do dual work: generating emotional appeal while also reducing uncertainty. The objective is to understand what identity is being communicated and how consistently that identity is activated across content systems.

3.1 Destination Narrative & Visual Identity

Across the website, Timor-Leste is positioned through three dominant narrative pillars:

1. **Off-the-beaten-path exploration -** The destination is framed as undiscovered, remote, and rewarding for independent travelers. Language emphasizing exploration, authenticity, and low tourism density appears consistently across activity pages and destination descriptions. Remoteness is presented as an asset rather than a limitation.
2. **Marine richness and biodiversity -** Coral Triangle positioning, diving experiences, whale and dolphin sightings, and coastal landscapes form a central part of the identity. Marine environments are among the most visually and narratively emphasized assets.
3. **Cultural identity and lived heritage -** History, independence narratives, village life, markets, and traditional practices are integrated into destination pages and thematic sections. Cultural content is generally serious in tone, positioning Timor-Leste as meaningful and historically distinct rather than leisure-oriented.

These themes are coherent and internally aligned. They are also broadly consistent with how Timor-Leste is framed externally in international media and by tour operators. The identity being presented is clear: Timor-Leste is remote, authentic, nature-rich, and culturally grounded.

Descriptive Strength vs Experiential Activation

While narrative identity is consistent, it is often descriptive rather than experiential. For example, marine wildlife pages describe biodiversity and migration windows in detail, but do not always translate this into trip-based framing. Cultural pages articulate history and meaning, yet rarely structure experiences in time-bound formats (e.g., half-day visits, village encounters, festival participation).

Imagery Deployment and Visual Consistency

Marine photography, coastal landscapes, and selected destination pages successfully convey remoteness and environmental richness. Where hero imagery is present and well-rendered, it reinforces the destination's positioning effectively. However, visual deployment is uneven across content systems.

Several structural patterns reduce visual impact:

- As mentioned in the technical assessment, directory and accommodation templates display unrendered shortcode artifacts or raw metadata in place of structured content blocks.
- Some municipality and listing pages lack strong header imagery or use image layouts inconsistently.
- Human presence — travelers, guides, communities engaged in activities — appears less frequently than landscapes.

As a result, imagery often supports place awareness more than experience imagination. The visual identity reinforces beauty and remoteness, but less frequently shows participation.

Key Takeaways — Narrative & Identity:

What works: Timor-Leste's three narrative pillars (remoteness/frontier appeal, marine biodiversity, and post-independence cultural identity) are consistently reflected across official and third-party channels. This narrative coherence provides a credible and differentiated awareness hook for niche segments.

Key limitations: The narrative remains descriptive rather than experiential. It conveys what Timor-Leste is, but rarely translates that identity into structured, plannable experiences with clear sequencing, duration guidance, or booking pathways.

3.2 Journey-Stage Content Gaps

This section evaluates how effectively the official tourism website supports progression across the five stages of the digital travel journey. The objective is not to assess content volume, but to assess progression logic: does the site reduce uncertainty at each stage, or does momentum weaken between stages?

1. Awareness (Dreaming)

At the Awareness stage, the site performs well. The homepage clearly communicates core themes (marine, mountains, culture) and reinforces feasibility through visible flight network references and access guidance.

Activity pages such as *Snorkelling & Diving*, *Whales & Dolphins*, and *Hiking & Walking* provide strong thematic hooks. Visual identity reinforces remoteness and biodiversity.

However, inspiration is largely distributed across standalone pages. Seasonal cues (e.g., whale migration windows) are mentioned but not connected to broader trip framing. There is limited sequencing guidance such as “Best 7-day marine-focused visit”, “Combine mountains and coast in one week”, “October–December wildlife route.”

As a result, inspiration exists, but it is not narratively stitched into coherent trip imagination.

2. Researching (Evaluation & Planning)

This stage represents the clearest structural weakness. The site contains itineraries under *Recommended Itineraries*, which is a major asset. However, internal inconsistencies reduce reliability. For example:

- The itinerary index labels “Atauro Island Visit” as **4 Days**, while the itinerary detail page presents it as **2 Days**.
- “Explore Dili to Jaco” appears as **2 Days** on the index but expands to **4 Days** in the detailed version.

Because duration is a primary Research-stage question (“How long do I need?”), these contradictions complicate the process. There are also no itineraries that introduce the destination generally (“7 days in Timor-Leste”). With the specific city or place references, the site’s existing itineraries may be more intended for travelers with existing experience or knowledge.

Activity pages also lack standardized planning scaffolding:

- *Whales & Dolphins* describes species and season but does not provide a clear “Where to base yourself” or “Typical tour format” section.
- *Fishing* outlines experience types but does not anchor them geographically.
- Cultural pages explain meaning but rarely define half-day or full-day visit structures.

The result is that visitors must put the information together themselves rather than following structured progression.

3. Booking (Conversion & Validation)

Directories and operator references are present. Examples include “fFind a diving centre” embedded in the snorkelling page, certified operator references in marine wildlife sections, and accommodation directory filters by municipality and listing type.

However, template reliability undermines confidence. Accommodation search has returned permission errors during testing. Several accommodation listings display shortcode artifacts (e.g., “[su_section]”) and raw metadata. Terms & Conditions page includes an unrelated embedded text line, which raises governance concerns.

At this stage, presentation errors can affect trust. The Booking stage requires clean, decision-grade templates.

4. Experience (On-Ground Preparation)

This is a relative strength. Pages such as *Safety & Health*, *Arriving in Timor-Leste*, and *Transport* provide concrete and realistic guidance, including crocodile warnings, ocean current notes, 4WD requirements, electronic entry form instructions, and more.

Expectation-setting is transparent and practical. For remote destinations, this reduces anxiety and builds credibility.

The limitation is not content absence, but fragmentation. Arrival guidance, transport advice, and safety tips exist in separate areas rather than as a consolidated pre-departure checklist.

5. Sharing (Post-Visit Advocacy)

The site references #HauNiaTimorLeste and includes news posts, some with 2025 timestamps. However, the site currently has no visible curated traveler story feed, visitor testimonials are not systematically surfaced, and user-generated content is not visibly integrated.

Given strong diving and hospitality sentiment observed in international media and in review sentiment, the official site does not actively amplify post-visit validation.

The table below summarizes these dynamics:

Table 3.2 - Journey Stage Content Gaps

Journey Stage	Strengths	Friction Points	Structural Effect
Awareness	Strong thematic identity; marine & culture clearly positioned; strong imagery	Inspiration not sequenced into trip archetypes	High curiosity, low structure
Researching	Itinerary system exists; activity diversity	Duration inconsistencies; lack of standardized “how to experience” modules; weak internal stitching	Planning momentum slows

Booking	Operator references present; directory filters exist	Template artifacts; form access issues; inconsistent CTA visibility	Trust erosion at decision point
Experience	Detailed safety, arrival, and transport guidance	Fragmented presentation	Strong pre-departure reassurance
Sharing	Hashtag reference; dated posts	Limited UGC amplification; no structured story feed	Advocacy remains niche

The primary structural weakness lies between Awareness and Booking, specifically in the Researching stage. The friction arises from inconsistent planning scaffolding, weak internal stitching between systems (activities → itineraries → operators), and template reliability issues.

3.3 Content Gaps by Traveler Segment

This section evaluates how effectively the official tourism website reaches the traveler segments identified in the first report. The key question: Does the website provide decision-ready scaffolding aligned with how each segment plans?

While all four segments encounter similar structural barriers (limited itinerary depth, weak booking pathways), each segment has a distinct friction point and a distinct area of strength.

- Adventure/Eco travelers face gaps in activity sequencing
- Marine/Diving travelers lack technical dive specification
- Cultural travelers find experiences described but not structured as plannable units
- Backpackers need realistic budget and route transparency

Adventure & Eco-Exploration Travelers

Where content performs well	Structural gaps	Effect
This segment aligns closely with the destination's core narrative identity. Pages such as Hiking & Walking, Mount Ramelau content, and highland municipality pages communicate remoteness and exploration effectively. Transport pages realistically note 4WD requirements and road conditions, which supports expectation-setting.	Planning scaffolding remains inconsistent: - No standardized difficulty grading system for hikes. - Gear expectations not structured into quick-reference format. For example, Mount Ramelau is described as a highlight, but there is no consistent "If you have 7 days, here is how to integrate this hike" pathway.	The segment remains interested, but must self-assemble route logic.

Marine & Diving Travelers

Where content performs well	Structural gaps	Effect
Marine biodiversity is clearly articulated. The Snorkelling & Diving page references the Coral Triangle. Whales & Dolphins identifies seasonal windows (October–December). Operator listings for dive centers are embedded in certain pages. This aligns strongly with external perception and review sentiment.	However, marine content is fragmented: - No centralized marine hub aggregating diving, cetaceans, beaches, and logistics - Limited technical dive information (depth ranges, current strength, skill-level suitability) - No visual map connecting dive zones to base locations - Sailing/yachting information is minimal, including notable lack of dedicated pages The Whales & Dolphins page discusses responsible practice but does not operationalize visitor-facing guidelines (distance rules, best launch points, typical tour duration).	The segment perceives high biological value but lacks structured reassurance at the Researching stage.

Cultural & Experiential Couple Travelers

Where content performs well	Structural gaps	Effect
Cultural and historical identity is well articulated. Resistance history, markets, heritage buildings, and Portuguese-era architecture are clearly described. Editorial tone supports credibility.	Cultural experiences are rarely structured as plannable units: - No half-day / full-day cultural modules. - Event listings appear primarily as a calendar table rather than as narrative planning assets. For example, markets and museums are described but not consistently framed in time-bound formats that help couples structure a balanced itinerary.	The segment aligns intellectually with the destination but may struggle to visualize pacing and sequencing.

Backpackers & Independent Travelers

Where content performs well	Structural gaps	Effect
Accommodation directories are filterable by municipality. Practical information on transport and safety is transparent. The authenticity narrative resonates strongly with this segment.	This segment relies less on official storytelling and more on peer platforms. Nonetheless: - No structured independent route guidance (e.g., “Backpacker-friendly 10-day route”). - Budget tiers are not clearly surfaced in listings. Planning likely occurs outside the official ecosystem. The site supports baseline information but does not actively structure independent route-building.	Timor Leste cedes control over this group’s trip planning to other sources, influencers, or media, instead of being the central point of truth.

3.4 Structural Diagnosis Summary

The destination's core identity — remote, marine-rich, culturally grounded, and non-commercialized — is coherent and consistently communicated. Visual assets reinforce this identity effectively, particularly in marine and landscape content.

Across journey stages and segments, the primary structural weakness emerges at the Researching stage. Duration inconsistencies in itinerary listings, uneven activity-to-itinerary linking, fragmented marine information, and template reliability issues reduce decision readiness.

In addition, template artifacts and formatting inconsistencies in accommodation and directory pages weaken perceived professionalism at precisely the moment where trust must peak.

Priority Tier 1: Trust & Structural Stabilization

The first priority is technical and presentational stability. Before expanding storytelling, the site must ensure that:

- Accommodation listings and directories render cleanly without shortcode artifacts or metadata errors
- Search and filter functions operate consistently without permission errors
- Itinerary durations are reconciled across index and detail pages
- Formatting consistency is restored in high-traffic planning sections

Priority Tier 2: Planning Spine Strengthening

Once stability is ensured, the second priority is building a visible planning spine across the site. This involves standardizing how experiences are structured rather than adding large volumes of new content.

Key structural enhancements may include:

- Clear duration framing across activities ("Half-day", "Full-day", "2–3 day extension")
- Standardized "How to experience this" modules on activity pages
- Improved internal stitching between activities, itineraries, and operator listings
- Consolidated marine hub content aggregating diving, cetaceans, beaches, and logistics
- More consistent geographic anchoring for activities

Priority Tier 3: Narrative Activation & Segment Deepening

With stabilization and structural clarity in place, narrative expansion can be more strategically leveraged. This includes:

- Greater experiential framing of cultural and marine activities
- Increased human presence in imagery to reinforce participation, not only place awareness

- Segment-specific route archetypes (e.g., marine-focused week, highland adventure loop, cultural circuit)
- Amplification of post-visit validation (traveler stories, curated visual feeds, testimonials)

Key Takeaway — Structural Diagnosis: The structural gap between awareness and planning capacity is consistent across all sections of this assessment. Closing this gap does not require new platforms or major investment — it requires content governance decisions: building itinerary depth, consolidating operator directories, standardizing QA protocols, and creating clear booking pathways. The next deliverable will sequence these actions by priority and feasibility.

4. Comparative Benchmark of Reference Tourism Websites

The previous section evaluated timorleste.tl on its own structural and narrative terms. This section introduces a comparative lens. Three reference destinations were selected for the analysis in Destination Visibility and Reputation Assessment, and are carried through in this report.

- Indonesia (indonesia.travel) was chosen as the dominant regional benchmark and Timor-Leste's most direct competitive frame of reference, given shared geographic proximity and overlapping traveler segments.
- Papua New Guinea (papuanewguinea.travel) was selected as a proximate small-island destination with similarly niche adventure and dive positioning, providing a relevant structural comparison for a low-infrastructure context.
- Solomon Islands (visitsolomons.com.sb) was included as an emerging Pacific destination with comparable marine and cultural assets.

Together, these three destinations represent a spectrum from high-resource digital maturity (Indonesia) to developing-destination contexts (PNG, Solomons) relevant to Timor-Leste's current positioning trajectory.

The benchmark focuses on structural packaging:

- How experiences are organized into planning pathways
- How events are surfaced and made usable
- How itineraries are structured and presented
- How operator discovery and booking handoff are integrated
- How logistical guidance reduces uncertainty

In digital tourism ecosystems, destinations often compete on similar thematic ground — nature, culture, adventure. A key differentiator, then, is not content breadth, but how efficiently that content moves travelers from inspiration to structured evaluation and commitment.

This section examines the planning architecture and conversion infrastructure of reference destinations to identify structural contrasts, not to score aesthetic superiority. The purpose is to clarify which observed differences reflect scale advantages, and which reflect transferable structural practices.

The following subsections analyze planning packaging patterns and journey-stage progression dynamics before synthesizing competitive implications for Timor-Leste.

4.1 Planning Architecture & Content Packaging Differences

Across all three reference destinations, the strongest structural differentiator is not content volume, but how content is packaged into visible planning pathways.

Each competitor translates inspiration into structured planning tools in ways that reduce cognitive load at the Researching stage. The difference is not thematic — marine, culture, and adventure are common across all four destinations — but architectural.

Across competitors, five packaging patterns are consistent:

1. Visible planning hubs segmented by decision type
2. Itinerary pages structured as decision-support tools
3. Embedded operator discovery within activity templates
4. Events formatted as standalone planning triggers
5. Multilingual capability

These patterns reduce friction at the Researching stage and protect momentum toward Booking.

Table 4.1 – Comparative Planning Architecture & Packaging

Destination	Visible Planning Hub	Itinerary Packaging	Event Structuring	Operator Integration	Multilingual Capability
Timor-Leste	Planning content exists but distributed across pages	Itinerary hub present; duration inconsistencies between index and detail	Calendar-style table; limited standalone event pages	Activity-level operator references; directory templates show inconsistencies	Core content in English
Papua New Guinea	Dedicated “Plan Your Trip” hub with segmented subpages	Semi-product pages with nights, price, inclusions, Enquire CTA	Standalone event pages with structured fields	Itineraries route to operators via clear CTAs	15-language capability

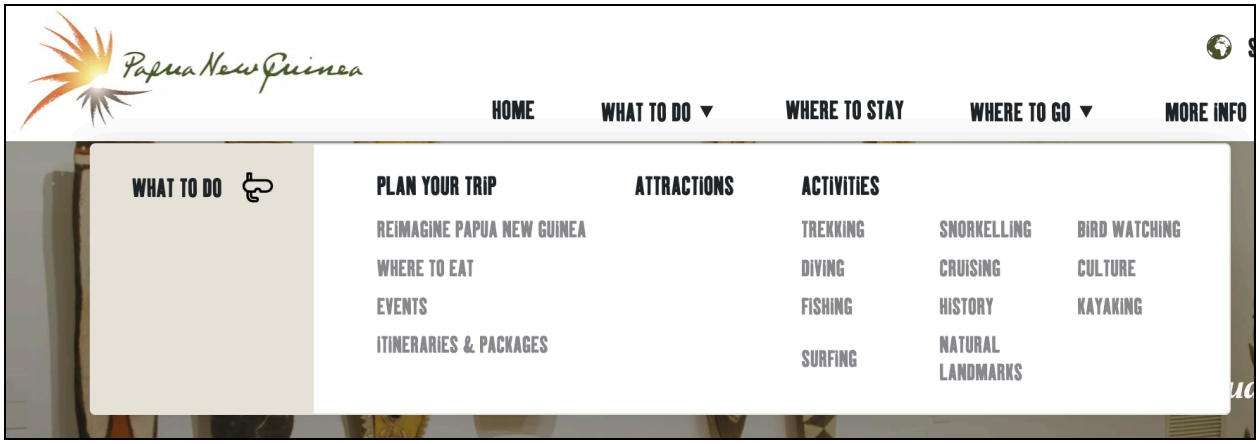
Solomon Islands	“Plan Your Adventure” hub with clear sub-navigation	Editorial itinerary content + package specials	Small events page, events can be integrated with user’s calendar	Embedded provider sections + booking forms	English
Indonesia	Template-driven destination hubs	“Trip Ideas” modules + some priced packages	Upcoming events surfaced across hubs	Embedded travel packages; operator visibility varies	Multi-language variants

The following subsections explore each of these planning architecture points in detail.

4.1.1 Planning Hubs as Entry Products

Both Papua New Guinea and Solomon Islands treat “Plan Your Trip” as a structured system rather than a secondary navigation page.

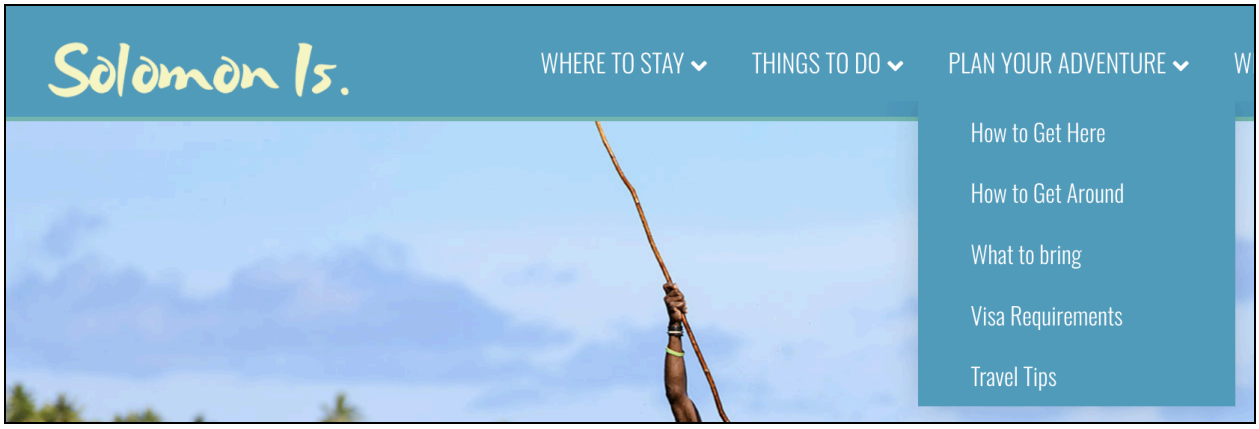
Figure 4: Planning Dropdown from Papua New Guinea (papuanewguinea.travel)



The homepage prominently features “Plan Your Trip,” which expands into clearly segmented subpages: Events, Itineraries & Packages, Travel Requirements, and Getting Around. Each subpage answers a discrete planning question without requiring long narrative reading.

The “Getting Around” page is particularly structured, with mode-by-mode breakdowns (air, road, sea), named airlines, safety realism, and route logic. This functions as a decision-support tool rather than descriptive copy.

Figure 5: Plan Your Adventure from Solomon Islands (visitsolomons.com.sb)



Similarly, “Plan Your Adventure” operates as a gateway page with visible sub-links: How to Get Here, How to Get Around, What to Bring, Visa Requirements, and Travel Tips. The structure mirrors traveler mental models.

Timor-Leste contains comparable material (arrival, transport, safety), but it is distributed across pages rather than consolidated under a visible planning spine.

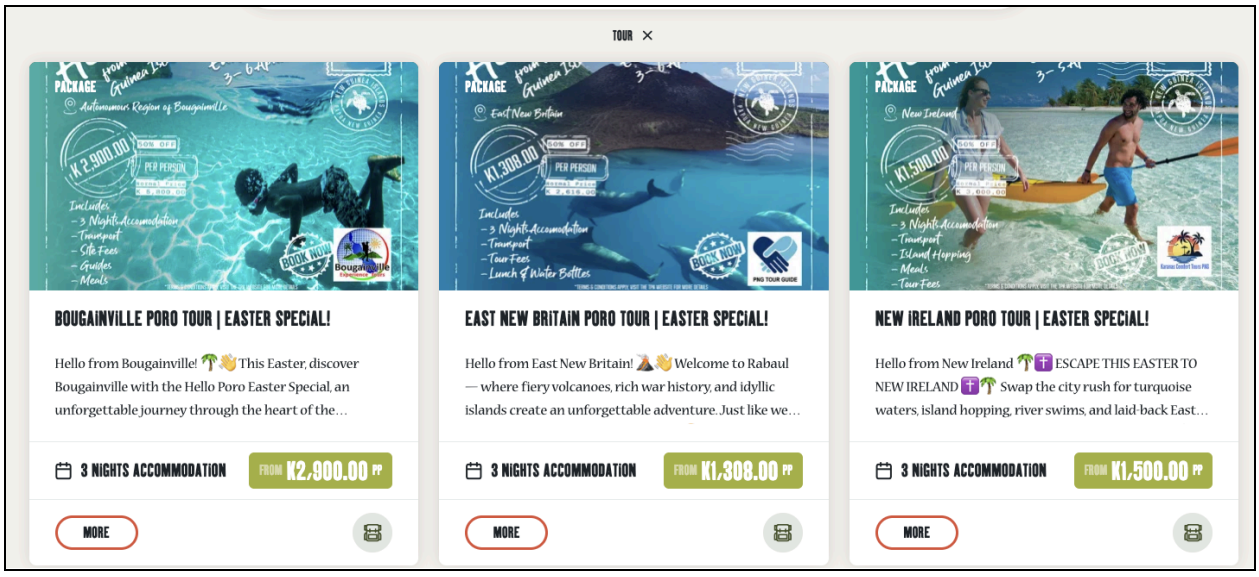
4.1.2 Itineraries as Semi-Commercial Planning Assets

One of the clearest comparative differences lies in itinerary packaging. **Papua New Guinea** presents itinerary and package pages that include:

- Number of nights
- Starting price
- Inclusions/exclusions
- Accommodation references
- Prominent “Enquire” or “Visit Website” CTAs

These function as semi-product pages, not full booking engines, but structured commitment surfaces.

Figure 6: Packaged Itineraries from Papua New Guinea



Solomon Islands integrates traveler-facing editorial itineraries (e.g., “Ultimate 7-Day Itinerary”) alongside “Specials” and package windows with defined travel dates. This gives travelers tangible timing anchors.

Indonesia embeds “Trip Ideas” modules inside destination pages and frequently integrates “Nearby” recommendations and transport guidance directly within the page template. Even without explicit pricing, the structure supports sequencing and comparison.

Timor-Leste has an itinerary hub. The comparative gap is not absence, but rather consistency and packaging clarity.

In competitor sites, itinerary pages often answer four questions quickly:

- How long?
- Where do I stay?
- What is included?
- What is the next step?

Where those answers are incomplete or inconsistent, progression slows.

4.1.3 Operator Discovery as an Integrated Layer

Competitor sites make tour operator discovery visible and embedded rather than isolated.

Solomon Islands integrates “Providers” sections within activity pages and maintains a site-wide “search machine” that filters by keyword, category, province, and activity. The discovery tool persists across the site.

Papua New Guinea routes from itinerary pages to operators through structured CTAs. Even when the final transaction occurs externally, the pathway is clear and confidence-oriented.

Indonesia varies in operator directory visibility, but flagship pages often include “Travel Package” modules with visible “Book Now” prompts embedded directly within destination content.

These mechanisms shorten the distance between inspiration and contact.

Timor-Leste includes operator references (e.g., dive centers on snorkelling pages; certified operators for whale tours). However, the presentation layer is inconsistent. Template reliability issues in accommodation and listing pages weaken the perceived professionalism of the discovery layer.

4.1.4 Events as Planning Anchors

Having accurate events related to what’s happening in the destination is another key differentiator, not just because events add content volume, but because they influence timing decisions.

For many travelers, especially those considering lesser-known destinations, the question is not only “Why should I go?” but “When should I go?” Events help answer that.

Structured event systems perform three planning functions:

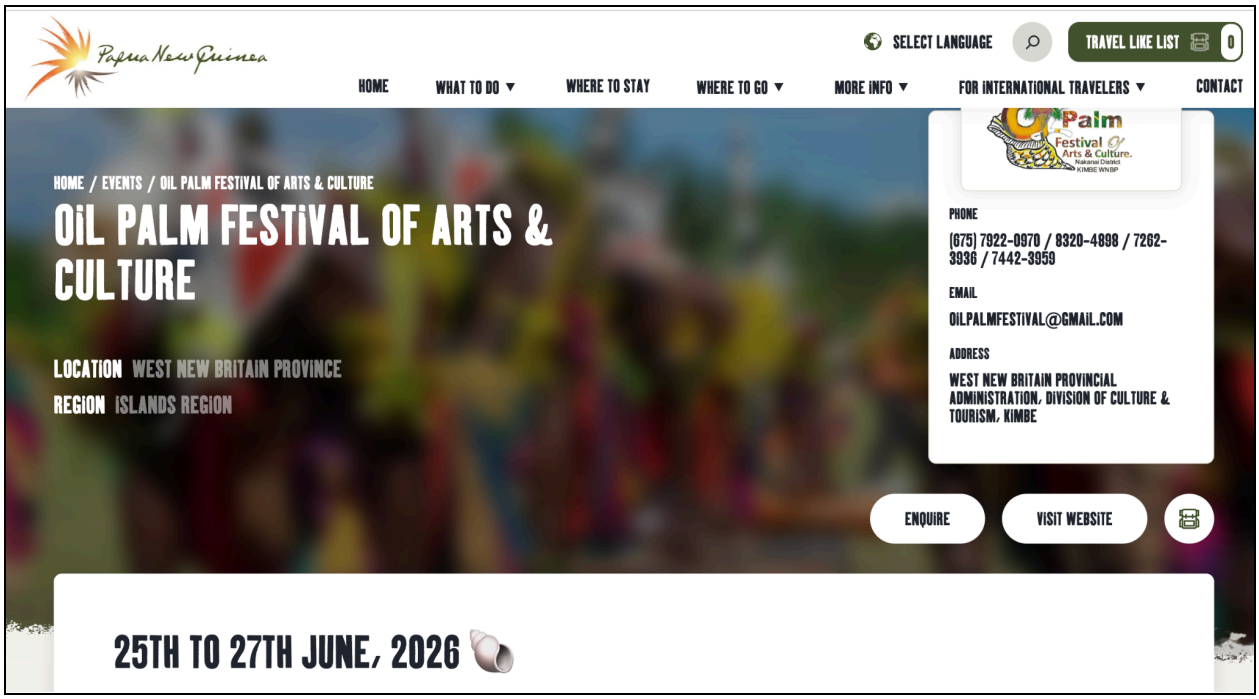
1. **They anchor seasonality -** Festivals, regattas, cultural celebrations, and wildlife-related events give travelers a reason to choose specific months.
2. **They create urgency and relevance -** An event with a visible date range signals that something is actively happening now. This reduces the perception that a destination is static or dormant.
3. **They support itinerary integration -** When events are structured as standalone pages (with location, dates, contact details, and suggested activities), they can be directly incorporated into trip sequencing.

Papua New Guinea presents events as individual pages with:

- Structured fields (location, region)
- Contact information
- Detailed schedules
- Clear date framing

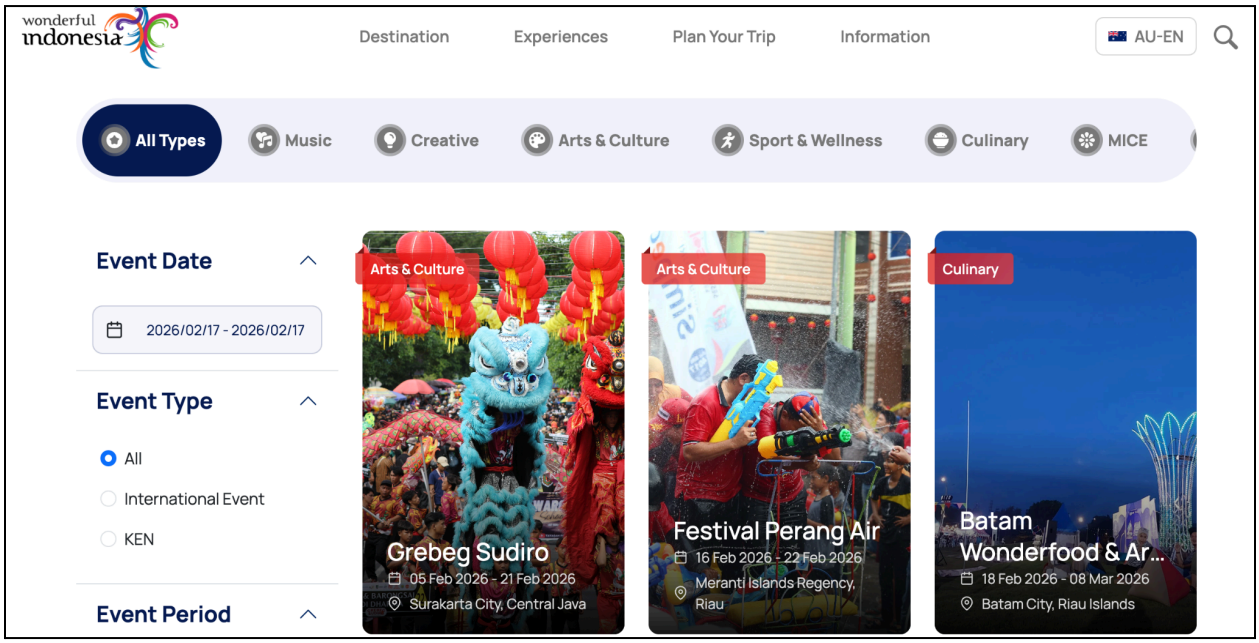
This makes events scannable, shareable, and integratable into itineraries.

Figure 7: Event Details from Papua New Guinea



Indonesia surfaces “Upcoming Events” prominently and integrates event visibility into region hubs.

Figure 8: Event Filters from Indonesia



By contrast, Timor-Leste’s events are presented primarily as a calendar table. While useful for reference, table format reduces scannability and shareability. It signals activity, but less strongly signals structured participation.

4.1.5 Multilingual Reach and Scale

Indonesia's primary structural advantage is multilingual reach and scale. Visible language-localized routes (English, French, German, Chinese, etc.) expand access and reduce friction for non-English audiences.

Papua New Guinea also supports multi-language capability (15 languages indicated).

Timor-Leste's core content is presented in English. While appropriate for many priority markets, this limits accessibility relative to competitors with active translation systems.

However, multilingual expansion represents scale strategy rather than core structural necessity. The more transferable insight from competitors is not translation volume, but planning clarity.

Across competitors, the most consistent structural advantage lies in visible planning segmentation and decision-grade itinerary packaging. Timor-Leste possesses many of the underlying content components; the comparative difference lies primarily in integration consistency and conversion-layer polish rather than thematic depth. The next section examines how these structural differences translate into journey-stage momentum and drop-off patterns.

Key Takeaway — Comparative Planning Architecture & Packaging: Comparator destinations demonstrate structural elements Timor-Leste currently lacks at scale:

- Dedicated planning hubs that consolidate trip-planning options in one place
- Semi-commercial itinerary pages that reduce research friction
- Integrated operator discovery layers
- Events as planning anchors
- Multilingual integration for reach and scale

These are content and governance decisions — not technology investments — and are achievable within Timor-Leste's existing digital infrastructure.

4.2 Comparative Conversion Infrastructure

While Section 4.1 examined structural packaging differences, this section evaluates how those structural choices translate into journey-stage momentum.

All four destinations communicate marine, cultural, and adventure themes effectively at the Awareness stage. The comparative differences emerge primarily in how consistently they sustain progression into Researching and Booking.

Rather than evaluating individual features in isolation, the table below maps relative strength of journey-stage support based on observed planning clarity, conversion signaling, and visible trust indicators.

Table 4.2 – Comparative Journey-Stage Momentum

Destination	Awareness	Researching	Booking	Experience	Sharing
Timor-Leste	Strong — clear proposition + visible access cues (flight corridors, updated route map reference)	Moderate — itinerary asset exists but internal inconsistencies reduce sequencing confidence	Weak — accommodation form blockage + directory/template inconsistencies create trust leakage	Strong — detailed safety, transport, and entry guidance; realistic expectation-setting	Moderate–Weak — hashtag initiative present; publishing cadence less visibly systematized
Papua New Guinea	Very Strong — dated stories (incl. 2026), events, and social integration reinforce currency	Very Strong — structured planning hub + detailed logistics + priced itinerary pages	Strong — inquiry-based semi-product pages with inclusions and nights clearly stated	Strong — comprehensive visa, customs, and transport realism	Strong — “Journeys” content product + visible social integration
Solomon Islands	Strong — emotional positioning + simple access framing	Strong — segmented “Plan Your Adventure” + persistent search filters	Strong — Book Now / Inquiry forms + specials and packages	Strong — practical logistics and cultural guidance clearly structured	Strong — steady publishing cadence with dated feature articles
Indonesia	Very Strong — scale + multilingual reach + visible upcoming events	Strong — consistent destination templates (“Get There,” “Nearby,” “Trip Ideas”)	Moderate — packages visible on flagship pages; discovery reliability varies	Strong — robust travel guide hub + regulatory updates	Strong — built-in influencer and hashtag modules

Timor-Leste’s conversion infrastructure is functional but fragmented. Comparators demonstrate that journey momentum is sustained through visible booking pathways, consolidated call-to-action pages, and sequenced content that moves travelers from inspiration to commitment. Addressing these gaps requires content architecture decisions rather than new technology.

4.3 Competitive Positioning Implications

The benchmark reinforces a focused strategic direction: strengthen journey stitching and conversion reliability to unlock existing narrative strength. If structural friction is reduced, Timor-Leste's existing advantages — marine differentiation, itinerary breadth, transparent logistical guidance — position it well to compete within its peer group.

1. Timor-Leste Competes on Authenticity, Not Scale

Indonesia competes on scale and multilingual reach. Papua New Guinea competes on structured planning clarity. Solomon Islands competes on segmented navigation and persistent discovery tools.

Timor-Leste's comparative advantage lies in authenticity, realism, and environmental distinctiveness. Attempting to compete on scale or volume would not be proportionate to resource realities.

The more relevant competitive arena is structural coherence, where improvements are achievable without large-scale expansion.

2. Structural Friction Suppresses Existing Strength

The benchmark shows that competitor sites do not necessarily offer more compelling stories. They make it easier for travelers to act on them.

Where planning pathways are clearer and conversion surfaces are stable, interest can lead to inquiry. For Timor-Leste, the risk is suppressed momentum. Strong identity can generate curiosity, but inconsistent planning clarity reduces structured follow-through.

3. The Opportunity Is Efficiency, Not Expansion

The comparative analysis suggests that the most impactful improvements are not new content verticals or complex booking infrastructure.

They are strengthening connective architecture, strengthening trip-planning resources, and clarifying planning pathways

In practical terms, this means Timor-Leste's competitiveness can improve through efficiency gains — enabling existing content to function more effectively — rather than through expansion alone.

5. Tour Operator Representation and Product Listing Quality

International tour operators play a decisive role in shaping how emerging destinations are understood in global markets. For many travelers, operator websites function as the primary planning interface: they

translate awareness of a destination or a niche into structured itineraries, clarify feasibility, and signal operational confidence.

This section evaluates how Timor-Leste is represented across international tour-operator channels. The focus is not on on-the-ground delivery, but on how clearly, accurately, and confidently the destination is presented to prospective travelers.

5.1 Analytical Scope

A total of **22 international tour operators** actively marketing Timor-Leste were identified through systematic desk research of publicly available listings.

For each operator, the review examined:

- Presence of a dedicated Timor-Leste landing page
- Up to five individual Timor-Leste itineraries
- Tour duration, routing, and geographic spread
- Inclusion of logistics, pricing, and operational detail

Representation levels indicate that Timor-Leste is meaningfully present in international distribution channels:

- **16 operators (73%)** publish fixed, scheduled departures with specific dates
- **4 operators (18%)** operate primarily on bespoke or request-based models
- **2 operators (9%)** maintain placeholder or incomplete listings

The prevalence of fixed departures signals operational confidence. Timor-Leste is not positioned solely as a speculative or inquiry-only destination.

Product Structure

Among the 18 operators specifying duration:

- **Average itinerary length:** 8.4 days (median 7.5 days)
- **Most products cluster:** 6–10 days
- Approximately two-thirds cover five or more named locations

A recognizable standard circuit appears repeatedly across operators: **Dili → Atauro → Maubisse → Mount Ramelau → Baucau → Jaco/Tutuala**

This pattern suggests emerging product normalization across the market. Operators are converging around a repeatable routing logic that reduces perceived operational risk.

Operators span multiple segment types:

- Global adventure brands
- Cultural and political-history specialists
- Marine and dive-focused providers
- Regional Asia-focused operators

This diversity indicates that Timor-Leste is not confined to a single niche. However, most operators rely on broadly similar routing and duration formats.

Overall, the constraint is not market presence. Timor-Leste is actively sold. The differentiation question lies in how it is explained and positioned within those listings.

5.2 Representation Quality Framework

To assess representation consistency, approximately 25,000 words of operator marketing and itinerary content were reviewed and coded using a structured analytical framework.

Four dimensions were applied:

1. **Presence & Commitment -** Degree of visible investment in Timor-Leste (dedicated landing pages, number of tours, fixed departures, completeness of listings).
2. **Accuracy & Clarity -** Specificity of itinerary detail, logistical realism, currency of information, and clarity of inclusions.
3. **Narrative & Experience Framing -** Strength of destination positioning, confidence of tone, and how remoteness and constraints are framed.
4. **Segment Alignment -** Coherence between itinerary structure and identifiable traveler segments (adventure, cultural, marine, etc.).

Each operator was scored on a 0–2 scale per dimension (maximum 8). Scores are used to identify representation patterns rather than rank operators.

Across the 22 operators, average scores reveal a clear imbalance:

Table 5.2 - Dimension-Level Summary

Dimension	Average Score (out of 2)	Interpretation
Presence & Commitment	1.64	Strong distribution presence
Segment Alignment	1.64	Clear positioning across major segments
Accuracy & Clarity	1.14	Moderate; uneven logistical detail
Narrative & Experience Framing	1.09	Moderate; restrained differentiation

The data indicate that Timor-Leste is widely presented as operationally viable and segment-relevant. However, representation quality tends to plateau at competent rather than distinctive.

Operators are confident enough to sell the destination. Fewer articulate a sharply differentiated “why Timor-Leste” narrative or provide highly specific experiential framing.

5.3 Thematic Positioning Patterns in Operator Portfolios

Tour-operator content does more than describe available experiences. It defines how international audiences categorize a destination. Themes that appear consistently become identity anchors; themes that appear rarely are perceived as niche, uncertain, or secondary.

Analysis of approximately 2,000+ thematic mentions across 22 operators reveals a pattern of strong narrative convergence combined with limited thematic diversity.

5.3.1 Dominant Narrative Pillars

Three themes dominate operator representation:

- **Cultural & Traditional Experience**
- **Adventure / Exploration**
- **Marine & Coastal Experience**

Cultural and traditional content is the most consistently articulated narrative strand. Operators such as Lupine Tours, Soviet Tours, and Young Pioneer Tours foreground independence history, village life, and heritage sites as the primary “why Timor-Leste” proposition. In these portfolios, culture is not an add-on, it is the organizing logic of the itinerary.

Adventure and exploration language appears across nearly all operators, though often generically (“remote,” “off-the-beaten-path,” “undiscovered”). Marine and diving experiences — particularly around Atauro Island — form the most geographically concentrated and commercially legible experience set.

Taken together, these pillars establish Timor-Leste internationally as:

- Culturally meaningful
- Exploratory rather than luxury-led
- Marine-oriented, especially in specialist portfolios

This coherence supports clarity. However, it also narrows perceived identity.

5.3.2 Mixed vs Siloed Itineraries

A notable pattern across operator portfolios is the degree of thematic mixing. Three broad positioning structures emerge:

1. **Culture-Led Itineraries** - Approximately 20% of operators - These programs are heavily weighted toward historical context, independence narratives, and village encounters. Nature and marine experiences appear as supporting elements rather than core drivers.
2. **Adventure-Led or Marine-Led Portfolios** - Approximately 15% - Specialist dive and cetacean operators focus almost exclusively on underwater and marine environments. In these cases, inland culture and highland landscapes are secondary or absent.
3. **Balanced Multi-Theme Itineraries** - Approximately 50% - Most operators combine culture, marine environments, and scenic highlands within a single 6–10 day circuit. These mixed itineraries are the dominant market format.

However, the mixing is often broad rather than deeply differentiated. Many itineraries follow similar routing and thematic composition, reinforcing a standardized perception rather than a distinctive one.

5.3.3 Under-Represented Experience Sets

Despite the thematic dominance above, several experience areas appear consistently under-represented:

- **Wildlife and Cetacean Tourism -** Whale and dolphin narratives are concentrated in a small number of specialist operators (e.g., Whale Expeditions, Free Dive Adventures). Mainstream portfolios rarely foreground Timor-Leste as a wildlife destination.
- **Inland Nature & Biodiversity -** Highlands, waterfalls, and terrestrial ecosystems are referenced, but often generically rather than as signature draws.
- **Food and Coffee -** Coffee appears intermittently and is rarely positioned as a defining experience, despite its agricultural and export relevance.
- **Portuguese Heritage as Architectural Narrative -** While visually prominent, colonial architecture and Portuguese-era identity are inconsistently framed as a core differentiator.

What operators mention frequently becomes what travelers assume is reliable and easy to access. What is mentioned rarely becomes perceived as niche or uncertain.

5.4 Strategic Relevance for Timor-Leste

At present, Timor-Leste is internationally legible as a culture-and-marine destination with an adventurous character. Some restraints include:

- Wildlife and cetaceans are not yet mainstream anchors
- Inland landscapes are not consistently articulated as distinctive
- Food and coffee narratives remain peripheral

If these experience sets are operationally ready and sustainably manageable, expanding how they are represented by tour operators could diversify perception without increasing inventory volume. Equally important is expectation-setting balance.

Most operators frame remoteness positively while minimizing discussion of road conditions, travel times, or service variability. Where expectation-setting is shallow, there is reputational risk if on-ground realities diverge from marketing tone.

From a digital positioning perspective, this section highlights two priorities:

1. Reinforce the strongest, most credible pillars (culture, marine, exploration) with greater specificity. This could be done by working with tour operators to provide more specific information.
2. Carefully broaden representation of under-leveraged themes where aligned with product readiness. This could include providing trade industry updates to agents and operators about new opportunities.

5.5 Market Readiness & Positioning Implications

The operator ecosystem demonstrates that Timor-Leste is actively sold, with scheduled departures, repeatable routes, and recognizable circuits. This signals baseline market confidence.

Across portfolios, representation tends to converge around a similar 6–10 day circuit combining Dili, Atauro, the highlands, and the eastern coast. Cultural and marine themes dominate, while wildlife, inland biodiversity, food, and Portuguese heritage remain secondary or specialist narratives.

This produces a clear but narrow international perception. Timor-Leste is understood as culturally meaningful, exploratory, and marine-oriented. It is less clearly positioned as wildlife-rich, nature-diverse, or culinarily distinctive.

From a strategic perspective, three implications follow:

1. The Destination Is Sellable but Standardized - Operators are comfortable selling a familiar format. Fewer differentiate beyond that baseline.

2. Expectation-Setting Requires Greater Consistency - Remoteness is widely framed as an asset, but logistical realities are unevenly communicated. Improved clarity around pacing, travel times, and service variability would strengthen confidence without diminishing appeal.

3. Differentiation Must Be Selective and Product-Led - If inland nature, cetaceans, culinary experiences (like coffee and food), or Portuguese heritage are to play a larger role in positioning, representation should expand only where operational readiness and experience quality are consistent.

Specifically, future digital efforts should prioritize:

- **Clearer “what to expect” framing -** Supporting operators with realistic descriptions of logistics, pacing, and travel conditions, particularly beyond Dili and Atauro.

- **Stronger, more specific storytelling -** Building on credible narratives already in use (culture, history, marine life), while avoiding generic adventure language that does not differentiate Timor-Leste from regional alternatives.
- **Careful expansion of the experience story -** Where products and infrastructure allow, increasing visibility of under-represented experiences — inland nature, wildlife, seasonal whale encounters, and coffee — with appropriate expectation-setting.

6. Destination Perception Mapping

The report on **Destination Visibility and Reputation Assessment** identified four priority traveler segments relevant to Timor-Leste's current digital visibility and product positioning.

These segments were derived from search trends, media coverage, review sentiment patterns, and international tour operator representation. This section deepens the analysis by mapping how each segment progresses through the digital travel journey — from awareness to researching, booking, experiencing, and sharing — and where Timor-Leste's current digital ecosystem supports or constrains that progression.

Perception mapping is based on:

- Global search trend analysis and keyword clustering
- Review platform sentiment analysis (TripAdvisor, Google Reviews, Booking.com)
- International tour operator content analysis
- Influencer and international media narratives
- External website audit findings

Detailed persona profiles and full digital journey maps are provided in Annex E.

6.1 Persona Snapshot Overview #1: Adventure, Eco-Exploration, Nature & Solo Traveler

This segment represents travelers drawn to Timor-Leste for its remoteness, biodiversity, and sense of personal discovery. This group is digitally engaged and tolerant of moderate logistical friction. They are motivated by authenticity, nature immersion, and low-tourism environments, and are typically comfortable assembling parts of a trip independently. The central question is whether the digital ecosystem provides enough structure to translate inspiration into a clear, time-bound route.

Table 6.1 - Digital Travel Journey: Adventure, Eco-Exploration, Nature & Solo Travel

Digital Journey Stage	Observable Digital Signals	What Performs Well	Where Progress Slows	Perception Outcome

1. Awareness (Dreaming)	- Media framing TL as “least visited” or “undiscovered” - Diving & marine curiosity spikes - Google Trends volatility	- Strong emotional hook (remote, authentic) - Diving consistently highlighted - High narrative distinctiveness vs Indonesia/PNG	- Limited inspirational structuring on official site - Media often frames logistical difficulty early	High curiosity. Destination perceived as rare and meaningful, but abstract.
2. Researching (Evaluation & Planning)	- “Things to do in Timor-Leste” - Review reading (Tripadvisor, Booking, Google) - Accommodation searches	- Solo travelers show longer stays - Transport sentiment stronger than expected	- Very low itinerary-search volume - Limited structured route guidance - Internal content connections fragmented	Interest sustained, but planning requires effort. Some drop-off likely at mid-funnel.
3. Booking	- Hotel searches in Dili - Visa and flight research	- Accommodation ratings generally strong - Dive operators validated through reviews	- Weak presence in structured tour listings	Booking likely for confident, self-directed travelers. Conversion niche but real.
4. Experience (On-Ground)	- Reviews referencing diving, beaches, hospitality - Transport feedback - WiFi and breakfast comments	- Diving strongest sentiment category across all platforms - Beaches outperform competitors in tone - Warm hospitality consistent	- Room consistency variability - Infrastructure expectations misaligned for some	Experience exceeds expectations for target segment; friction tolerable for adventurous travelers.
5. Sharing (Post-Visit Advocacy)	- Long-form travel reflections - YouTube documentation	- Highly positive marine storytelling - Authenticity frequently emphasized	- Advocacy remains niche and not systematized	Strong advocacy within the adventure niche; limited spillover to mainstream markets.

Persona 1 Key Takeaway: This is Timor-Leste's most research-intensive audience — highly motivated, but quick to lose confidence without clear itinerary scaffolding. Unlike the marine segment, which is

anchored by specialist operators, adventure travelers can be more self-directed: if official channels cannot show them how to build a trip, they will piece it together from informal sources that may underrepresent the full offering.

6.2 Persona Snapshot Overview #2: Marine, Diving, Sailing & Yachting Traveler

This segment represents the most clearly validated high-value niche in Timor-Leste's current digital footprint. Marine biodiversity — particularly diving — as the strongest cross-platform sentiment category, supported by influencer coverage and specialist operator representation.

These travelers are technically informed and comparison-oriented. They evaluate destinations based on reef quality, seasonal conditions, safety, and operational clarity. Unlike broader adventure travelers, they require precise and credible information before committing.

Table 6.2 - Digital Travel Journey: Marine, Diving, Sailing & Yachting

Digital Journey Stage	Observable Digital Signals	What Performs Well	Where Progress Slows	Perception Outcome
1. Awareness (Dreaming)	- Diving-specific searches - "Best diving in [destination]"	- Strong positioning as pristine and under-dived - Marine uniqueness credible	- Low sustained visibility beyond niche coverage	Awareness is targeted and high-quality but limited in scale.
2. Researching (Evaluation & Planning)	- Review reading (Tripadvisor, Google) - Dive operator comparisons - Accommodation searches near dive hubs	- Dive sentiment strongest across all platforms - Authentic reef narrative - Positive transport surprise factor	- Limited detailed marine operational content - Sparse technical dive specs (depths, currents, skill level guidance)	Engagement high but reassurance incomplete. Planning sophistication not fully met.
3. Booking	- Direct dive operator inquiries - Hotel bookings in Dili - Visa and flight research	- Small-scale operators seen as personal and warm - Strong review credibility	- Lack of consolidated booking pathways - No centralized marine hub content	Conversion occurs — but largely for confident niche travelers.

4. Experience (On-Ground)	- Reviews praising reefs and marine life - Transport and guide commentary - Infrastructure notes	- Diving = highest sentiment category - Low diver density valued	- WiFi reliability - Equipment logistics sometimes unclear	Experience validates marine positioning strongly.
5. Sharing (Post-Visit Advocacy)	- Dive blogs - Underwater video content - Forum discussions - High-quality imagery	- “Hidden gem” reinforcement - Technical praise from experienced divers	- Advocacy not systematically amplified - Remains within niche circles	Strong niche authority; limited mainstream spillover.

Persona 2 Key Takeaway: This segment is the closest to booking-ready — but their decisions hinge on technical specificity. Divers require precise information (dive conditions, depths, certification requirements, operator quality) before committing resources. Closing this gap on official channels is the single highest-return improvement available within Timor-Leste's existing digital presence.

6.3 Persona Snapshot Overview #3: Cultural, Experiential & Couple-Oriented Travelers

This segment is shaped primarily by editorial discovery and values-based travel motivations. This is seen in how the international media coverage frequently frames Timor-Leste through narratives of independence, identity, resilience, and lived culture.

These travelers are drawn to destinations that feel meaningful and authentic. They respond to historical context, community interaction, and experiential depth rather than checklist tourism. However, they are typically less tolerant of ambiguity in planning and pacing than independent solo explorers.

Table 6.3 - Digital Travel Journey: Cultural, Experiential & Couple-Oriented

Digital Journey Stage	Observable Digital Signals	What Performs Well	Where Progress Slows	Perception Outcome
1. Awareness (Dreaming)	- International media coverage emphasizing independence history - “Least visited” framing	- Editorial credibility - Cultural differentiation vs Indonesia	- Heavy emphasis on context over experience - Limited inspirational structuring on official site	High intellectual interest. Destination perceived as meaningful and serious.

	- Informational searches			
2. Researching (Evaluation & Planning)	- “Things to do in Timor-Leste” - Review reading	- Positive hospitality sentiment - Strong authenticity validation in reviews	- Limited time-bound activity presentation - Cultural experiences not structured as plannable units	Values align, but the trip remains abstract. Planning clarity is weak.
3. Booking	- Hotel searches - Visa research - Limited international packaged presence	- Accommodation ratings generally strong - Direct booking pathways functional	- Weak representation in international operator listings - Cultural products not packaged clearly	Booking occurs selectively; scale limited.
4. Experience (On-Ground)	- Reviews emphasizing warmth and authenticity - Commentary on food, hospitality, transport	- Warm hospitality consistently praised - Cultural authenticity reinforced	- WiFi and service consistency issues - Limited guided cultural structuring reflected in reviews	Experience generally positive and aligned with expectations.
5. Sharing (Post-Visit Advocacy)	- Reflective reviews - Long-form editorial-style storytelling	- Emphasis on authenticity and identity - Narrative depth in reflections	- Advocacy remains within niche readership - Limited scalable amplification	Strong narrative credibility; limited mainstream conversion impact.

Persona 3 Key Takeaway: These travelers arrive already persuaded by Timor-Leste's story. Unlike the marine segment, which needs technical confirmation, or the adventure segment, which needs itinerary structure, cultural travelers need online resources, including the official website, to answer: 'How do I spend 10 meaningful days here?' The narrative is in place, yet the practical architecture is not.

6.4 Persona Snapshot Overview #4: Backpackers & Budget-Oriented Independent Travelers

This segment engages with Timor-Leste primarily through peer-to-peer ecosystems rather than official planning channels. The previous report identified strong solo-traveler review signals and recurring "hidden gem" narratives across independent travel platforms.

These travelers are flexible, cost-conscious, and comfortable navigating destinations with limited infrastructure. Their planning behavior is often decentralized, relying heavily on online reviews, informal blogs, and booking platforms.

Table 6.4 - Digital Travel Journey: Backpackers & Budget-Oriented Independent Travelers

Digital Journey Stage	Observable Digital Signals	What Performs Well	Where Progress Slows	Perception Outcome
1. Awareness (Dreaming)	- "Least visited country" media - YouTube travel narratives	- Strong appeal of remoteness - Differentiation vs Bali mass tourism	- Limited backpacker-specific visibility - No structured budget travel framing	Destination perceived as adventurous and unconventional.
2. Researching (Evaluation & Planning)	- Accommodation searches - Review reading (Tripadvisor, Google, Booking)	- Solo traveler presence evident - Transport sentiment stronger than expected	- Limited official planning scaffolding - Peer-to-peer information dominates	Planning largely bypasses official content. Independent route-building behavior.
3. Booking	- OTA accommodation bookings - Direct low-cost lodging searches	- Functional booking channels - Generally strong accommodation ratings	- Limited budget-tour packaging - No structured independent route guidance	Booking decentralized and self-directed.
4. Experience (On-Ground)	- Reviews discussing rooms, WiFi, breakfast, service	- Warm hospitality - Beaches and nature appreciated - Transport performance positive	- WiFi frequently cited as weakness - Infrastructure variability	Experience aligns with expectations of low-development context.
5. Sharing (Post-Visit Advocacy)	- Tripadvisor & Booking reviews - Social media documentation	- Strong authenticity reinforcement - "Hidden gem" narrative repeated	- Advocacy scale limited - Influence mostly within independent travel networks	Contributes to organic awareness but not structured demand growth.

Persona 4 Key Takeaway: This segment already trusts the destination — the 'hidden gem' narrative reaches them through peer networks before they ever visit the official site. Unlike other segments, they do not need to be converted; they need to be prepared. Transparent, honest information about transport, costs, and infrastructure limitations prevents the post-arrival surprises that generate the negative reviews that damage the destination's reputation with future travelers.

6.5 What the Four Persona Journeys Reveal

Across segments, the digital ecosystem requires visitors to assemble coherence independently. Information exists, but it is distributed across parallel systems rather than integrated into a clear planning spine. Four cross-segment constraints recur:

1. **Limited duration framing -** Few structured pathways answer the practical question: “How long do I need, and how should I sequence this?” Itinerary assets exist, but they do not consistently function to support any of the mentioned segments.
2. **Fragmented thematic consolidation -** Marine, cultural, highland, and coastal experiences are available, but the themes aren’t fully owned by the site with deep, useful pages that make trip-planning clear. Travelers must infer how experiences connect geographically and temporally.
3. **Uneven connective architecture** - Internal linking between activities, itineraries, operators, and practical logistics is present but inconsistent. Movement from inspiration to booking requires additional effort.
4. **Trust-surface variability at decision points -** Template inconsistencies, presentation artifacts, and uneven packaging at listing and booking layers introduce minor but disproportionate confidence erosion during high-intent moments. Also a lack of incorporating reviews and niche-specific UGC is a missed opportunity to generate trust.

7. Priority Actions and Recommendations

This section draws together the main findings from across the report and translates them into five concrete action areas. Each area is grounded in a specific pattern identified during the assessment — of the website's technical health, content structure, competitive position, operator representation, and traveler behavior. The actions are sequenced to reflect what matters most first. They do not require building a new website or changing Timor-Leste's positioning. They require making what already exists work harder and more consistently.

7.1 Fix What Is Broken Before Building What Is New

Several pages that travelers rely on most — accommodation listings, operator directories, and itinerary pages — contain visible technical errors: broken text fragments (displayed as raw code), permission errors on search and filter tools, and contradictory trip duration information.

What to do

- **Audit accommodation and operator directory pages** for broken formatting: any page showing raw code fragments (visible text like [su_section] or similar), missing images, or permission errors should be identified and corrected as an immediate priority.
- **Restore the search and filter function** on the accommodation directory, which has returned errors during testing. This tool is a key part of how visitors compare options — unreliable performance at this stage creates unnecessary friction.
- **Reconcile itinerary durations.** The same itinerary currently shows different lengths on the index page and the detail page (e.g., listed as 7 days in one place, 8 in another). These inconsistencies undermine trust when a visitor is trying to plan a specific trip.
- **Introduce a basic content checklist** used before any page is published or updated: does the page render correctly? Are images loading? Are all links working? Is the contact information current? A simple internal process prevents errors from accumulating.

7.2 Make Trip Planning Easier to Navigate

The website contains good content about individual experiences — diving, hiking, culture, beaches — but it does not connect them in a way that makes trip-planning straightforward. A potential visitor can find that diving exists and that Mount Ramelau is a highlight, but they cannot easily find a clear answer to: 'How do I plan a 7-day trip?' or 'What should I do if I only have 5 days?' Benchmark destinations — even smaller ones in the same region — offer more structured planning pathways, which is a key reason interest converts into actual bookings more reliably.

What to do

- **Add clear duration labels to all major activities.** Simple labels such as 'Half-day from Dili', 'Full day', or '2-3 day extension' answer the most common planning question without requiring a visitor to read the full page to find out.
- **Add a short 'how to experience this' section to each major activity page** — covering getting there, what to bring, who to contact, and how this activity connects to other nearby things to do. This converts informational content into practical planning guidance.
- **Create a dedicated marine hub page** that brings together diving, snorkelling, whale-watching, and sailing content in one place with links to relevant operators. Currently this content is scattered across multiple separate pages, making it hard for the segment most likely to book — marine and diving travelers — to find what they need.

- **Strengthen the connections between activity pages, itinerary pages, and operator listings.** A visitor reading about hiking should be able to click directly to a related itinerary and from there to a relevant operator. Currently these pathways are incomplete, requiring visitors to find connections themselves.

7.3 Make the Content More Specific to Each Type of Traveler

Timor-Leste's digital content is largely undifferentiated. The website presents the same information to all visitors regardless of why they are traveling. A serious diver, a couple drawn to history and culture, a solo adventurer, and a budget backpacker each have different questions, different planning timelines, and different reasons to choose Timor-Leste.

Currently, the site does not speak directly to any of them. International operators are also selling a narrow, standardized circuit, and experience areas with genuine potential (wildlife, inland nature, coffee country) are almost entirely absent from digital content.

What to do

- **Develop 3 to 4 named route suggestions** framed around specific traveler types: for example, a marine-focused week, a highland adventure loop, a cultural and heritage circuit suited to couples, and a lower-cost independent route for backpackers. These do not need to be fully packaged products (this is the responsibility of the tour operators to provide). A clearly labeled suggested itinerary with practical notes is sufficient.
- **Add operational detail to marine and diving pages.** Technical divers want to know: How deep are the dive sites? What are the typical current conditions? What skill level is required? Which months are best for specific marine species? This information exists in the operator community — it needs to be published on the official site to give this high-value segment the reassurance they need.
- **Reframe cultural pages as plannable visits rather than general descriptions.** Instead of describing Portuguese-era architecture as a historical feature, present it as: 'A half-day walk through Dili's historic quarter — what to see, where it is, and how long to allow.' This shift from information to practical guidance makes content useful at the planning stage.
- **Add short traveler stories or testimonials** — particularly from divers and returning visitors — to show what the experience actually feels like. Review sentiment is strongly positive, but this content is currently absent from the official site. It does not need to be elaborate: a short first-person quote alongside a photo is enough to make the destination feel real and validated.

7.4 Support the Operators Already Selling Timor-Leste

Twenty-two international tour operators already include Timor-Leste in their programs. This is a meaningful base of distribution, but the assessment found that most are selling the same circuit. New experience areas are not being sold because operators do not have the content or product infrastructure

to support them. Operators also rely on destination websites and materials to reassure buyers — and gaps in official content limit how confidently they can present Timor-Leste to their customers.

What to do

- **Create a trade partner section on the tourism website** with downloadable materials: suggested itineraries with routing logic, practical logistics by region, downloadable maps, and standardized 'what to expect' language covering infrastructure, transport, and entry requirements. This reduces the barrier for operators to build accurate and compelling programs.
- **Identify 2 to 3 experience narratives that operators could add to their programs** once infrastructure is ready. The most credible candidates based on this assessment are cetacean and wildlife tourism, inland trekking and highland biodiversity, and coffee country. Brief operators on these narratives in advance of product development so they can begin positioning the destination more broadly.
- **Review Timor-Leste's listing quality across key operator websites** and reach out where important practical information is missing or out of date. Operators want to sell. They often just need better source material to do so more confidently and accurately.

7.5 Maintain What You Build

Many of the technical and formatting issues identified across the website — broken listings, outdated content, inconsistent formatting — suggest that there is currently no routine quality review process for published pages. Errors accumulate because no one is checking regularly. As the website expands and more content is added, this risk grows. Digital content that is published and then not maintained quickly becomes a liability rather than an asset.

What to do

- **Assign clear ownership** for the website's highest-traffic sections: accommodation, activities, planning guides, and operator directories. A named person or small team should be responsible for each area, with defined accountability for keeping content accurate and functional.
- **Schedule regular content reviews** — quarterly at a minimum — to update seasonal information (whale migration windows, dive conditions by month, festival dates), refresh images, fix broken functionality, and remove or correct outdated listings.
- **Use the content checklist introduced in Action 7.1** for all new page publications and updates. This does not require technical expertise — it requires a habit of checking before publishing.

These five action areas are sequenced deliberately. Technical trust comes first, because improvements elsewhere are undermined if the pages visitors rely on most are unreliable. Planning architecture comes second, because it converts existing interest into action. Traveler-specific content, operator support, and ongoing maintenance follow — each building on the layer before it.

Timor-Leste does not need a new story. Its narrative identity — remote, marine-rich, culturally distinctive, non-commercialized — is already credible and differentiated. What it needs is the structural scaffolding that allows that story to move a visitor from curiosity to a confirmed trip.

Glossary of Key Terms

The following terms appear throughout this report. Definitions reflect their specific usage in the context of destination digital marketing and this assessment. Acronyms are listed separately in the Acronyms section.

Awareness / Dreaming Stage — The first stage of the Digital Travel Journey, in which a potential traveler becomes inspired by a destination — typically through media coverage, social content, or word-of-mouth — without yet actively planning a trip.

Benchmark / Comparator Destination — A reference destination used to assess relative digital performance. In this report, Indonesia, Papua New Guinea, and Solomon Islands serve as comparator destinations against which Timor-Leste's digital presence is evaluated.

Booking Pathway — The sequence of steps — and the digital content supporting them — that guide a traveler from expressed interest to a confirmed booking or inquiry. A clear booking pathway reduces decision friction and increases conversion.

Booking Stage — The point in the Digital Travel Journey at which a traveler commits to a purchase or inquiry — typically a flight, accommodation, or tour booking. Strong conversion architecture (clear CTAs, consolidated booking pathways) is required to support this transition.

Call to Action (CTA) — A prompt on a web page that directs a visitor to take a specific next step, such as 'Book Now', 'Enquire', 'Plan Your Trip', or 'Contact an Operator'. CTAs are a critical element of conversion architecture.

Canonical URL — The preferred version of a web page URL, specified to prevent search engines from treating duplicate or similar pages as separate, competing content. Inconsistent canonical URL handling can reduce search visibility.

Content Architecture — The structural organization of digital content — how pages are linked, sequenced, and categorized — to support user navigation and decision-making. Weak content architecture means relevant information exists but is difficult for visitors to find or connect into a coherent trip plan.

Conversion — The moment a potential traveler transitions from passive interest or research into an active booking, inquiry, or purchase. Conversion rate refers to the proportion of visitors who complete this transition.

Conversion Architecture — The combination of digital structures — booking interfaces, call-to-action buttons, consolidated inquiry pages, and sequenced content flows — that facilitate the transition from inspiration to booking. Conversion architecture is distinct from awareness content: it functions at the Booking stage rather than the Awareness stage.

Core Web Vitals — A set of standardized performance metrics defined by Google to assess the user experience quality of a web page. The three primary metrics are: Largest Contentful Paint (LCP) — how quickly the main content loads; Cumulative Layout Shift (CLS) — visual stability as the page loads; and

Interaction to Next Paint (INP) — responsiveness to user input. Core Web Vitals are a factor in Google's search ranking algorithm.

Crawlability — The ability of search engine bots (automated programs) to access, read, and index a website's pages. A website with poor crawlability may not appear in search results even if its content is high quality.

Digital Travel Journey — A five-stage framework describing the online decision process of international travelers: Awareness (Dreaming) → Researching (Evaluation & Planning) → Booking → Experience (On-Ground) → Sharing (Post-Visit Advocacy). This framework, adapted from standard destination digital marketing practice, structures the diagnostic approach used throughout this report.

Experience (On-Ground) Stage — The phase during which a visitor is physically at the destination. Digital content (maps, offline guides, event listings) continues to influence the on-ground experience and sets the conditions for post-visit advocacy.

Hero Image — The large, dominant visual element at the top of a web page, typically the first image a visitor sees. Hero images are critical for first impressions and establishing a destination's visual identity.

Influencer — A content creator with an established online audience — typically on YouTube, Instagram, or TikTok — who publishes travel content that reaches and influences potential visitors. Influencer coverage contributes to destination awareness, particularly in niche travel segments.

Itinerary Packaging — The presentation of structured, pre-designed trip sequences — typically including day-by-day activities, duration guidance, accommodation suggestions, and price indications — that reduce research friction and move travelers toward booking.

Narrative Pillar — A core thematic message or story that anchors a destination's identity across digital channels. Timor-Leste's three identified narrative pillars are: remoteness and frontier appeal, marine biodiversity, and post-independence cultural identity.

Niche Segment — A clearly defined, specialized traveler group with specific motivations and behaviors — such as divers, eco-explorers, or cultural heritage travelers — as opposed to mass-market tourists. Timor-Leste's current digital performance is strongest within niche segments.

Organic Search — Unpaid website visits generated through search engine results pages (e.g. Google), as opposed to paid advertising. Strong organic search performance depends on SEO optimization, content quality, and technical website health.

OTA (Online Travel Agency) — A digital platform that allows travelers to search, compare, and book travel products (flights, accommodation, tours) from multiple providers in one place. Examples include Booking.com, Expedia, and Agoda. OTA listings are an important source of international visitor bookings.

Planning Hub — A dedicated section of a tourism website that consolidates itinerary options, practical logistics, and booking pathways in a single accessible location. Planning hubs reduce the need for visitors to navigate across multiple pages to build a trip plan.

Planning Scaffolding — The structural content elements that help a traveler build a concrete trip plan: itineraries with duration and sequencing, transport and logistics guidance, activity descriptions with

booking information, and practical tips. Planning scaffolding is what converts destination inspiration into confirmed travel.

Researching / Evaluation & Planning Stage — The stage at which a traveler actively compares destinations, reads reviews, explores itineraries, and begins to build a concrete trip plan. This is the stage where structural planning content (itineraries, activity pages, logistics guidance) has the greatest influence on conversion.

Sentiment Analysis — The process of systematically assessing the tone and emotional content of user-generated text — such as reviews on TripAdvisor or Google — to determine whether overall perception of a destination or product is positive, negative, or neutral. In this report, sentiment data is drawn from platform reviews and social content, not from primary surveys.

SEO (Search Engine Optimization) — The practice of improving a website's structure, content, and technical characteristics to increase its visibility and ranking in unpaid (organic) search engine results.

Sharing / Post-Visit Advocacy Stage — The final stage of the Digital Travel Journey, in which visitors publish reviews, photos, blog posts, and social content about their trip. Strong advocacy generates organic awareness for future travelers.

Tour Operator / Specialist Operator — A company that designs, markets, and sells packaged travel experiences, typically combining accommodation, transport, and activities. Specialist operators focus on specific niches (e.g. dive operators, eco-tourism operators) and are a primary distribution channel for destinations with limited mainstream awareness.

UGC (User-Generated Content) — Reviews, photographs, social media posts, blog articles, and other content created by travelers themselves rather than by official tourism bodies or professional media. UGC is a significant driver of destination awareness and credibility, particularly within niche travel communities.

Visitor Persona — A semi-fictional profile representing a distinct type of traveler, constructed from observed behavioral patterns, motivations, search behavior, and digital engagement signals. Personas are used in this report to assess how different traveler types experience Timor-Leste's digital ecosystem, and where friction points are most significant for each group.

XML Sitemap — A file that lists all pages on a website and signals to search engines when content was last updated, helping bots discover and index content efficiently. An outdated or incomplete sitemap can limit search visibility.

Annex A - Tour Operator Representation Scoring Framework

This scoring framework was developed to assess how Timor-Leste is represented by international tour operators in publicly available digital channels. The objective is not to evaluate operational quality or traveler satisfaction, but to understand market-facing representation, including visibility, clarity, narrative framing, and alignment with identified traveler segments.

The framework supports a consistent and transparent assessment of tour operator offerings and is intended to identify patterns and gaps in how Timor-Leste is positioned within international tourism distribution, rather than to rank or compare individual operators competitively.

Scope of Application

The scoring framework is applied only to international tour operators actively selling Timor-Leste through published itineraries or destination pages. Operators that do not offer Timor-Leste, or that reference the destination only incidentally (for example, in blog content or as a custom request), are not scored and are instead considered qualitatively in the main analysis.

Scoring is based exclusively on publicly accessible digital content, including:

- Operator websites
- Published itineraries
- Destination or tour overview pages
- On-page imagery and descriptive text

No assumptions are made regarding on-the-ground service quality, pricing competitiveness, or unpublished operational arrangements.

Scoring Scale

Each dimension is scored on a **three-point ordinal scale**, designed to balance simplicity with analytical usefulness.

Score	Definition
0	Absent, weak, or undermining representation
1	Present but limited, inconsistent, or cautious representation
2	Clear, confident, and supportive representation

Half-points are not used. Where evidence is ambiguous, the lower score is applied and contextualized through qualitative notes.

Scoring Dimensions and Criteria

1. Presence and Commitment

Assessment question: *How substantively is Timor-Leste offered within the operator's portfolio?*

This dimension evaluates the visibility and seriousness of the operator's engagement with Timor-Leste.

Indicative criteria

- Existence of a dedicated tour or destination page
- Regularity or recurrence of departures
- Ease of discovery within the site's navigation structure

Score	Interpretation
0	No dedicated presence; only ad hoc or historical references
1	Dedicated offering exists but is infrequent, seasonal, or difficult to find
2	Clear, visible offering with recurring departures and strong site presence

2. Accuracy and Clarity

Assessment question: *Is Timor-Leste explained clearly, correctly, and with sufficient practical context?*

This dimension assesses whether essential information is communicated in a way that supports traveler understanding and confidence.

Indicative criteria

- Geographic and itinerary clarity
- Practical information on access, logistics, and seasonality
- Absence of outdated, misleading, or overly vague content

Score	Interpretation
0	Confusing, inaccurate, or caution-heavy framing without context
1	Generally accurate but incomplete, vague, or hesitant
2	Clear, coherent, and confidence-building explanation

3. Narrative and Experience Framing

Assessment question: *What story is being told about the destination and its experiences?*

This dimension focuses on how Timor-Leste is positioned emotionally and experientially, rather than on writing quality or marketing polish.

Indicative criteria

- Dominant tone (exploratory, aspirational, cautionary, neutral)
- Emphasis on experiences versus constraints
- Consistency and coherence of the narrative

Score	Interpretation
0	Framed primarily through difficulty, risk, or deterrence
1	Neutral or factual, with limited experiential appeal
2	Coherent and engaging narrative aligned with destination strengths

4. Segment Alignment

Assessment question: *Is the offering clearly aligned with a specific traveler segment?*

This dimension evaluates whether the operator's presentation clearly signals *who the experience is for*, using cues related to pace, activity level, comfort expectations, and thematic focus.

Indicative criteria

- Alignment with identified traveler segments (e.g. eco & marine, adventure, cultural)
- Explicit or implicit signaling of target audience
- Consistency between itinerary design and narrative framing

Score	Interpretation
0	Target audience unclear or misaligned
1	Segment implied but weakly articulated
2	Clear and coherent alignment with a specific traveler segment

Scoring Consistency and Quality Control

To reduce subjectivity, scoring was conducted using a two-pass approach:

1. An initial scoring pass to capture overall impressions
2. A review pass focusing on high scores to confirm that strong representation was clearly evidenced

Qualitative notes accompany each score to document the rationale and support transparency.

Annex B - Website Performance Diagnostics & Priority Optimisation Actions

This annex provides the technical evidence underpinning the findings presented in Section 2 of the main report. It draws primarily on PageSpeed Insights diagnostics for the official tourism website (timorleste.tl), supplemented by crawl-based link integrity checks. The purpose of this annex is to document observed performance constraints, explain their likely causes, and outline a prioritized set of corrective actions.

1. Performance Testing Scope and Methodology

Performance diagnostics were conducted using Google PageSpeed Insights, which combines laboratory testing with modeled mobile and desktop environments. Tests were run for both mobile and desktop profiles to reflect differences in device capability, network conditions, and rendering behavior.

PageSpeed Insights was selected because:

- it aligns with Google's Core Web Vitals framework;
- it reflects quality signals used in search ranking and user experience evaluation;
- it allows consistent benchmarking against recommended thresholds.

Screenshots and full diagnostic outputs from both mobile and desktop tests are retained as part of this annex for transparency and reference.

2. Summary of Observed Performance Results

Desktop Performance (Snapshot)

Desktop performance scores are consistently high, indicating that the site performs well under favorable conditions.

Key indicators observed:

- Overall performance score: high (mid-90s)
- First Contentful Paint (FCP): under 1 second
- Largest Contentful Paint (LCP): close to 1 second

- Total Blocking Time (TBT): negligible
- Interaction responsiveness: strong
- Layout stability: acceptable

These results confirm that the site's infrastructure, page structure, and rendering logic are fundamentally sound.

Mobile Performance (Snapshot)

Mobile performance is significantly weaker than desktop, though still functional.

Key indicators observed:

- Overall performance score: moderate (high-50s range)
- First Contentful Paint (FCP): approximately 6 seconds
- Largest Contentful Paint (LCP): approximately 8–9 seconds
- Cumulative Layout Shift (CLS): elevated but not extreme
- Interaction metrics (e.g. INP): generally within acceptable ranges

The most critical constraint is delayed visual loading rather than interaction latency.

3. Interpretation of Core Web Vitals

Largest Contentful Paint (LCP)

LCP measures how long it takes for the most important visual element on a page to appear. On mobile, LCP exceeds recommended thresholds.

Likely contributors include:

- large hero images not sufficiently optimized for mobile delivery;
- absence of preloading for the LCP image;
- competing network requests delaying image fetch.

Impact:

- weaker first impressions;
- reduced perceived speed;
- potential competitiveness loss in mobile search results.

Cumulative Layout Shift (CLS)

CLS measures visual stability during page load. While CLS values are not extreme, visible shifts occur as images and dynamic elements load.

Likely contributors include:

- missing or inconsistent image dimensions;
- late-loading elements without reserved layout space;
- font loading behavior.

Impact:

- momentary confusion during page load;
- reduced perceived polish.

Interaction Metrics (INP / TBT)

Interaction metrics perform relatively well. Once content is loaded, the site responds promptly to user input.

Interpretation:

- JavaScript execution is not a primary bottleneck;
- performance issues are front-loaded (loading and rendering), not interaction-based.

4. Link Integrity Findings

A crawl of 268 pages identified only eight broken or unreachable links.

Characteristics of these links:

- primarily external URLs that have changed or expired
- a small number of typographical or legacy domain issues
- no broken internal navigation paths

This confirms strong ongoing editorial maintenance and does not indicate systemic technical debt.

5. Technical Fixes

Based on observed diagnostics, recommended actions are grouped by priority and effort.

High Impact, Low to Moderate Effort

These actions directly address mobile performance constraints and are likely to yield immediate gains.

1. **Optimize and prioritize hero imagery**
    - Serve responsive image formats (e.g. WebP / AVIF)
    - Reduce image file sizes for mobile

    - Explicitly preload the LCP image
2. **Improve loading order of critical resources**
    - Ensure critical CSS is delivered early
    - Defer non-essential JavaScript
    - Reduce render-blocking resources above the fold
3. **Stabilize layout during load**
    - Define width/height or aspect ratios for images
    - Reserve space for dynamic elements
    - Review font loading behavior

Priority 2: Medium Impact, Structural Refinements

These actions improve consistency and resilience rather than fixing immediate bottlenecks.

4. **Reduce unused CSS and JavaScript**
    - Audit and remove unused assets
    - Minimize bundle size for mobile
5. **Review third-party scripts**
    - Inventory analytics, embeds, and widgets
    - Remove or defer non-critical scripts
6. **Strengthen caching and compression**
    - Ensure long-lived cache headers for static assets
    - Confirm Brotli/Gzip compression is enabled

Priority 3: Monitoring and Governance

These actions support long-term performance stability.

7. **Introduce ongoing performance monitoring**
    - Track Core Web Vitals via Google Search Console
    - Monitor mobile performance trends over time
8. **Establish periodic link and performance checks**
    - Annual link integrity scan
    - Quarterly performance spot checks

6. Relationship to Main Report

The findings in this annex underpin Sections 2.2–2.4 of the main report. They confirm that:

- the website is technically stable and well maintained;
- performance constraints are concentrated in mobile visual loading;
- issues are solvable through targeted optimisation rather than redesign.

By separating diagnostics into this annex, the main report remains accessible and decision-focused, while technical teams retain a clear and actionable reference for implementation.

Annex C - Tour Operator Content Analysis Methodology and Scoring Framework

1. Purpose of the Analysis

This annex details the methodology used to assess how Timor-Leste is represented by international tour operators.

The analysis supports the Terms of Reference requirement to evaluate:

- Quantity of listings
- Accuracy of information
- Quality of presentation
- Competitiveness of product positioning
  Terms-of-Reference_26900 (1)

The objective is to assess **market-facing representation**, not on-the-ground performance or customer satisfaction.

2. Operator Identification and Inclusion Criteria

Identification Process

Operators were identified through:

- Search queries combining “Timor-Leste tour,” “East Timor tour,” “Timor-Leste itinerary”
- Review of major adventure and cultural tour brands
- Marine/dive specialist operator searches
- Regional Asia-focused operator review

Only operators actively publishing Timor-Leste listings at the time of review were included.

Inclusion Criteria

To be included in the analytical group, operators had to:

1. Maintain a publicly accessible Timor-Leste listing
2. Offer either:
    - A fixed-departure itinerary with dates, or

    - A clearly structured on-request program
3. Provide sufficient textual detail for evaluation

A total of **22 international operators** met these criteria.

3. Data Collection Scope

For each operator, the following content was extracted:

- Timor-Leste destination landing page (if available)
- Up to five Timor-Leste-specific tour listings
- Associated itinerary breakdowns
- Inclusions/exclusions
- Logistics descriptions
- Booking instructions
- Pricing structure (if visible)

Where operators offered multiple Timor-Leste tours, variation in length, geography, or theme was captured to assess depth of engagement.

Corpus Size

Approximately **25,000 words** of publicly available marketing and itinerary text were extracted and analyzed.

Content sources:

- Primarily English-language websites
- Three operators with French-only listings were machine translated into English to ensure consistency

Visual elements (photography, video, design) were not systematically coded, as the methodology prioritizes textual traceability.

4. Analytical Dimensions

The analysis was conducted using a structured, rule-based content analysis framework.

Four dimensions were evaluated.

1. Presence & Commitment

What it captures:
The degree of visible commercial commitment to Timor-Leste.

Indicators coded:

- Dedicated destination landing page (Yes/No)
- Number of Timor-Leste tours offered
- Fixed scheduled departures vs inquiry-only models
- Visibility within portfolio navigation
- Completeness of listing content

Why it matters:
Presence signals distribution seriousness and market confidence. Multiple tours suggest portfolio integration rather than experimental listing.

2. Accuracy & Clarity

What it captures:
Itinerary specificity and logistical realism.

Indicators coded:

- Day-by-day breakdown present
- Named locations specified
- Transport modes described
- Inclusion/exclusion clarity
- Currency of departure dates
- Absence of outdated or contradictory claims

Why it matters:
Timor-Leste is a low-familiarity destination. Specificity reduces uncertainty.

3. Narrative & Experience Framing

What it captures:
Tone, confidence, and how constraints are presented.

Indicators coded:

- Use of definitive vs hedging language (“will” vs “may”)
- Framing of remoteness (asset vs deterrent)
- Treatment of infrastructure limitations
- Presence of experiential storytelling
- Clarity of “why go” proposition

Constraint language was coded as:

- **Positively framed:**
  e.g., “remote,” “untouched,” “off-the-beaten-path adventure”
- **Deterrence-framed:**
  e.g., “limited infrastructure” without mitigation context

Why it matters:
Emerging destinations depend heavily on framing to manage perceived risk.

4. Segment Alignment

What it captures:
Coherence between product design and identifiable traveler segments.

Indicators coded:

- Dominant activity types
- Thematic emphasis (marine, culture, adventure, political history)
- Coherence of activity mix
- Implied target traveler profile

5. Thematic Coding Framework

Content was coded across ten destination attribute themes:

1. Nature and landscapes
2. Marine and diving
3. Cultural and traditional life
4. Historical and political narrative
5. Portuguese heritage
6. Adventure and exploration
7. Authenticity and remoteness
8. Wildlife and cetaceans
9. Food and coffee
10. Hospitality and people

Theme frequency and distribution were analyzed to identify:

- Dominant narrative patterns
- Niche specialization
- Underrepresented themes

6. Scoring Framework

Each operator was scored on a 0–2 scale per dimension.

Maximum possible score: **8 points**

Table C.1 – Scoring Criteria

Dimension	Score 0	Score 1	Score 2
Presence & Commitment	Placeholder or incomplete presence	Limited or primarily bespoke	Dedicated page + visible scheduled departures
Accuracy & Clarity	Missing or outdated detail	Partial specificity	Detailed day-by-day, clear logistics
Narrative & Framing	Generic or unclear value proposition	Competent but restrained	Clear experiential positioning and confident tone
Segment Alignment	Weak or incoherent targeting	Broad but diffuse	Clear alignment with identifiable segment

Score Interpretation

Score Range	Interpretation
6–8	Strong representation with credible, competitive positioning
4–5	Moderate representation with visible gaps
0–3	Weak or minimal representation limiting confidence

Scores are used to identify **market-wide representation patterns**, not to rank individual operators competitively.

7. Market Structure Signals Extracted

Beyond qualitative scoring, the following quantitative indicators were extracted:

- % of operators with fixed departures
- % offering multiple Timor-Leste itineraries
- Average itinerary length
- Geographic coverage breadth
- Presence of standard circuit patterns

These indicators provide insight into product normalization and operational confidence

8. Methodological Considerations & Limitations

This analysis:

Captures:

- Publicly visible textual representation
- Market-facing confidence signals
- Positioning patterns

Does not capture:

- On-the-ground service quality
- Actual traveler satisfaction
- Visual storytelling quality
- Commercial performance data

Machine translation was applied consistently where necessary to avoid language bias.

The rule-based framework prioritizes transparency and traceability over machine learning opacity.

9. Replicability

The methodology is fully replicable:

- Operators can be re-evaluated using the same 0–2 framework.
- Additional operators can be added without altering structure.
- Theme coding categories are fixed and documented.

This ensures methodological consistency for future roadmap updates.

Annex D - Thematic Analysis Keyword Definitions

This annex documents the keyword patterns used to identify thematic content in tour operator marketing materials. The analysis employed rule-based natural language processing with case-insensitive pattern matching across destination pages and tour package descriptions.

Keywords are matched using substring detection (e.g., "dive" matches "diving", "diver", "dived"). All matching is case-insensitive. The analysis counts the number of mentions per theme, not unique keywords matched.

1. **Natural Assets -** References to landscape features, scenery, natural beauty, and pristine environments

    a. Keywords: mountain, mountains, landscape, scenic, scenery, pristine, natural beauty, wilderness, rugged, untouched nature, spectacular, breathtaking
2. **Marine/Diving** - References to diving, snorkeling, underwater activities, and marine environments.
    a. Keywords: diving, dive, scuba, snorkel, snorkeling, underwater, coral, reef, marine life, dive site, liveaboard
3. **Cultural/Traditional** - References to cultural experiences, traditional practices, local communities, and heritage.
    a. Keywords: culture, cultural, traditional, tradition, heritage, village, community, local people, indigenous, ceremony, ritual, customs, craft
4. **Historical/Political -** References to independence, resistance history, political development, and historical narratives.
    a. Keywords: history, historical, independence, resistance, occupation, struggle, liberation, memorial, monument, conflict, political history
5. **Portuguese Heritage** - References to colonial-era architecture, Portuguese influence, and Lusophone culture.
    a. Keywords: portuguese, colonial, portuguese colonial, architecture, fort, fortress, cathedral, church, lusophone
6. **Adventure/Exploration** - References to adventure activities, exploration, trekking, and challenging experiences.
    a. Keywords: adventure, explore, exploration, trek, trekking, hike, hiking, expedition, journey, discovery, kayak, off-road
7. **Authenticity/Remoteness** - References to unspoiled destinations, off-the-beaten-path appeal, and authentic experiences.
    a. Keywords: authentic, remote, off the beaten path, off-the-beaten-path, undiscovered, unexplored, untouched, hidden, unspoiled, frontier
8. **Wildlife/Cetaceans** - References to whales, dolphins, marine mammals, and wildlife encounters.
    a. Keywords: whale, whales, dolphin, dolphins, cetacean, cetaceans, marine mammals, wildlife, whale watching
9. **Food/Coffee** - References to cuisine, culinary experiences, coffee production, and local food.
    a. Keywords: coffee, cuisine, culinary, food, local food, traditional food, meal, dining, restaurant, specialty coffee
10. **Hospitality/People** - References to local hospitality, friendly people, welcoming communities, and human connections.
    a. Keywords: friendly, hospitality, hospitable, welcome, welcoming, warm, local people, locals, community, people, smile

Keywords are detected using case-insensitive substring matching. For example:
- "mountain" matches: "mountain", "mountains", "mountainous", "Mountain"
- "dive" matches: "dive", "diving", "diver", "dived", "Dive Sites"

Counting Methodology:

- Each mention of any keyword within a theme increments that theme's count by 1
- Multiple keywords from the same theme in a single sentence count as multiple mentions
- Theme percentages calculated as: (Theme mentions / Total mentions across all themes) × 100

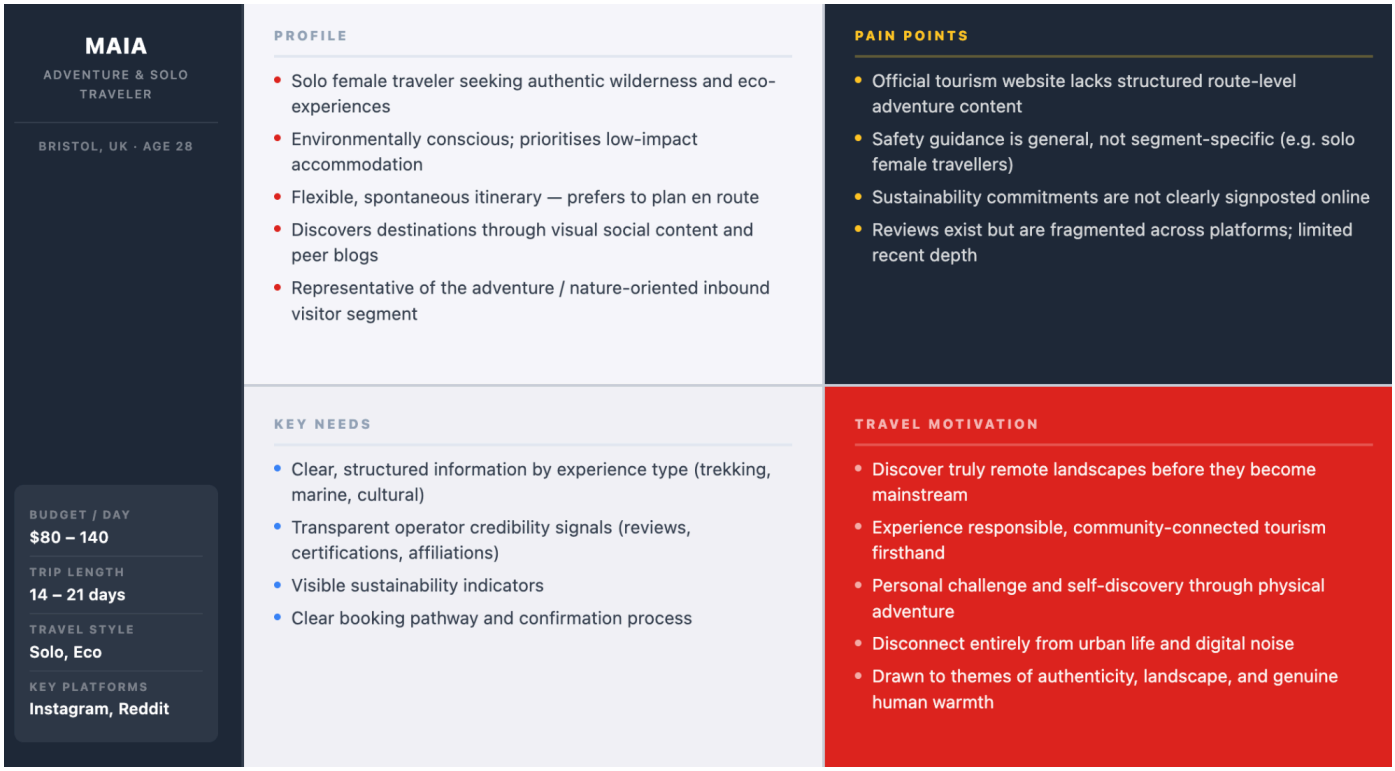
Content Sources Analyzed
- Destination overview pages (main Timor-Leste description)
- Individual tour package descriptions (up to 5 per operator)
- Tour titles and highlights sections
- Approximately 500-2000 words per operator depending on content depth

Annex E – Visitor Personas & Journey Maps

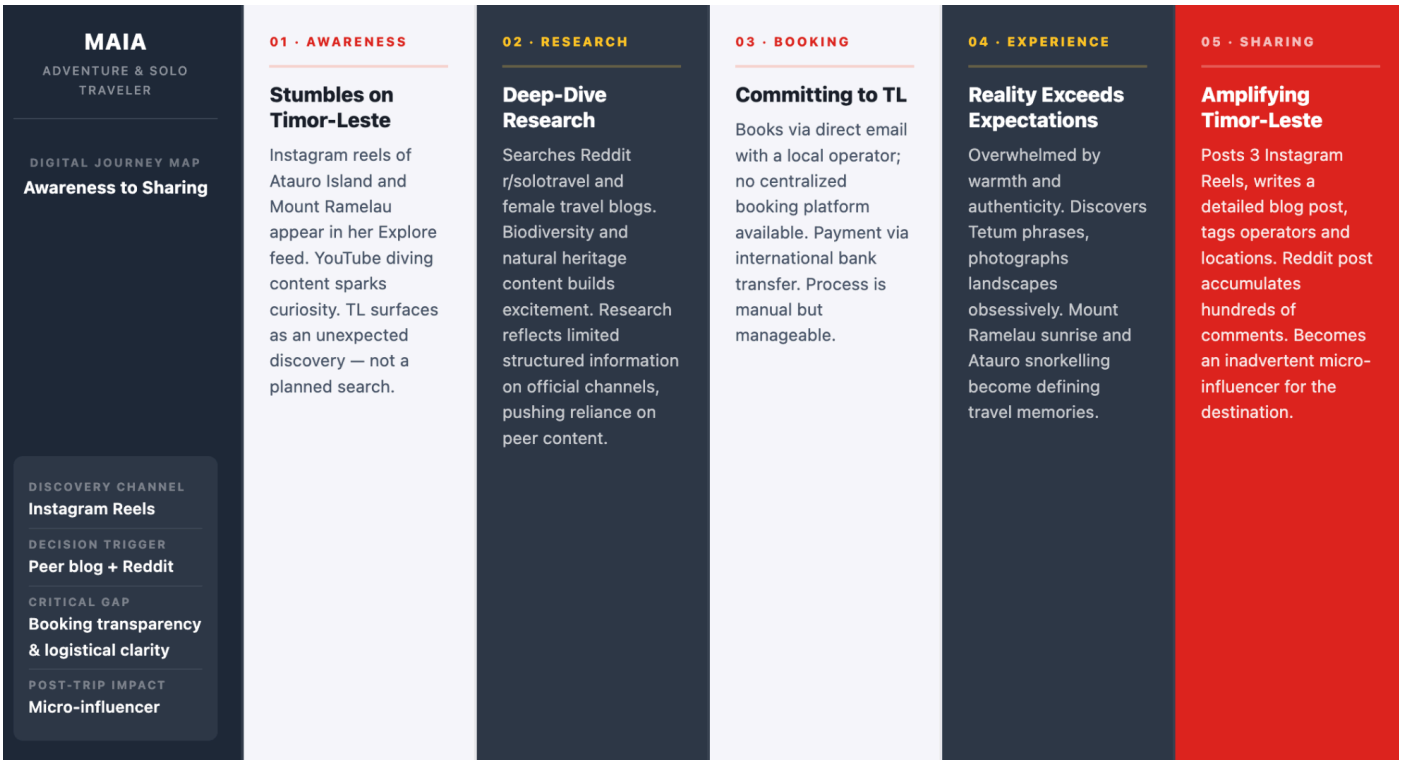
This annex provides the full persona profiles and journey visualizations referenced in Section6. These materials support transparency of analysis and illustrate how structural digital friction manifests across the traveler lifecycle.

Persona 1 – Adventure, Eco-Exploration & Solo Traveler

Persona Profile Snapshot

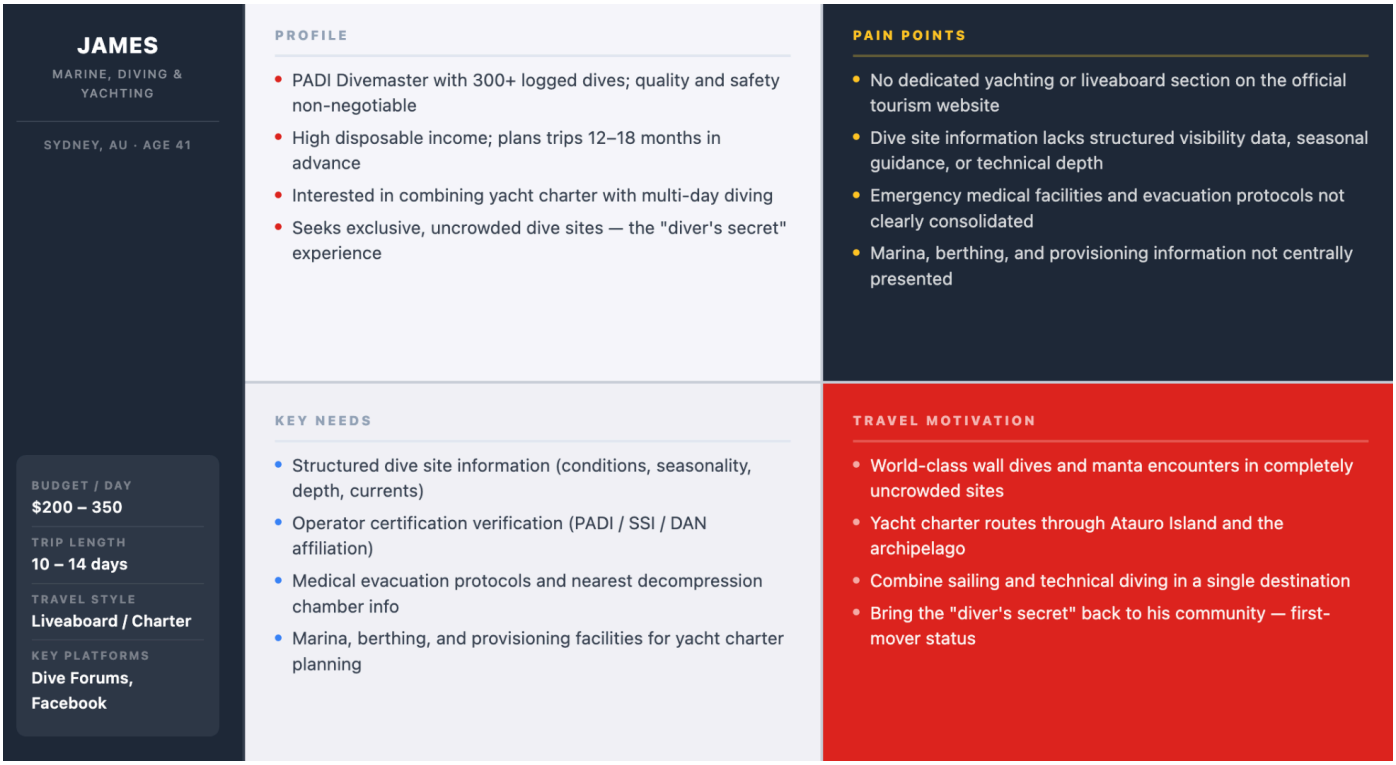


Digital Journey Flow

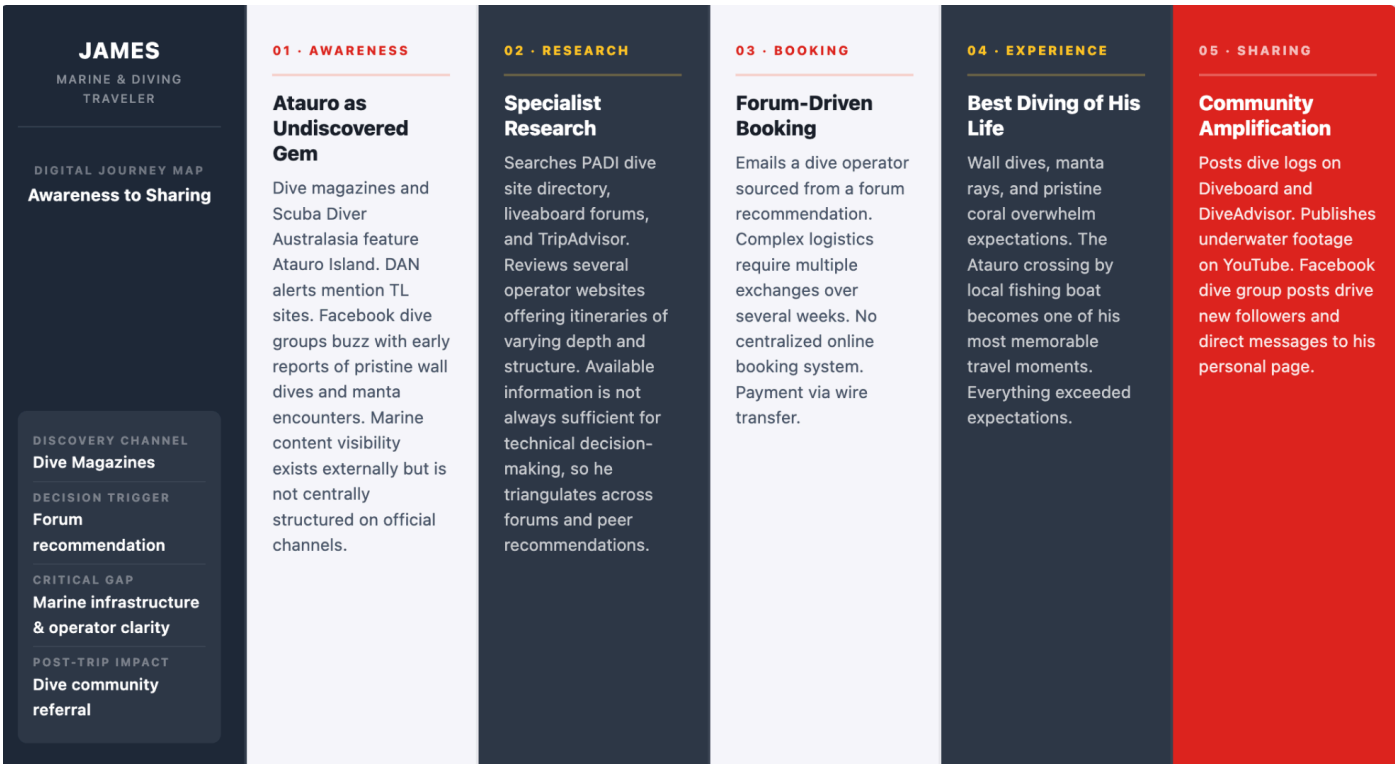


Persona 2 – Marine, Diving, Sailing & Yachting Traveler

Persona Profile Snapshot



Digital Journey Flow



Persona 3 – Cultural & Experiential Couples

Persona Profile Snapshot

SOPHIE
CULTURAL & COUPLE TRAVELER

AMSTERDAM, NL · AGE 37

BUDGET / DAY
$120 – 200

TRIP LENGTH
12 – 18 days

TRAVEL STYLE
Couple, Cultural

KEY PLATFORMS
Blogs, Pinterest, LP

PROFILE

- Traveling with partner; seeks cultural immersion over tourist circuits
- Photographer and food enthusiast; detailed planner 6+ months ahead
- Interested in history, post-conflict narratives, and community contact
- Medium-high budget; willing to pay more for authentic experiences

PAIN POINTS

- No clearly structured cultural itinerary guidance on official sites
- Locally rooted, community-based experiences are not easy to find online
- Tetum language basics and local customs minimally explained for visitors
- Boutique and couple-oriented accommodation not clearly highlighted

KEY NEEDS

- Curated cultural route options with historical and community context
- Community-based tourism contacts and vetted local guide referrals
- Food and market calendar — festivals, night markets, local produce
- Photography location guides with access and lighting information

TRAVEL MOTIVATION

- Understand Timor-Leste's unique Portuguese-Asian cultural fusion
- Witness post-conflict resilience and national identity in everyday life
- Photograph heritage sites and cultural landscapes
- Meaningful travel that goes beyond the resort experience

Digital Journey Flow

SOPHIE
CULTURAL & COUPLE TRAVELER

DIGITAL JOURNEY MAP
Awareness to Sharing

DISCOVERY CHANNEL
Longform & Podcasts

DECISION TRIGGER
Expat community guide

CRITICAL GAP
Structured cultural itinerary guidance

POST-TRIP IMPACT
Photography & blog reach

01 · AWARENESS

Long-Read Discovery

A longform article on Timor-Leste's post-independence story and a podcast on Southeast Asia's lesser-known destinations spark genuine curiosity. Photography blogs featuring cultural landscapes reinforce the interest.

02 · RESEARCH

Itinerary Planning Research

Looks through the Thorn Tree forum and reads additional longform travel articles. Reviews cultural itinerary ideas and local guide recommendations. Information is dispersed across sources and not always comprehensive.

03 · BOOKING

Multi-Touchpoint Booking

Finds a local cultural guide through an operator linked from the Timor-Leste tourism website. Books accommodation through a series of direct emails. Each element — flights, guide, stays — requires separate coordination. No unified booking experience exists.

04 · EXPERIENCE

Cultural Depth Surprises

Cristo Rei at dawn, Dili's Mercado Municipal, and an Atauro village homestay exceed expectations. Food discoveries — local tukir, coffee ceremonies — become the trip's most talked-about moments.

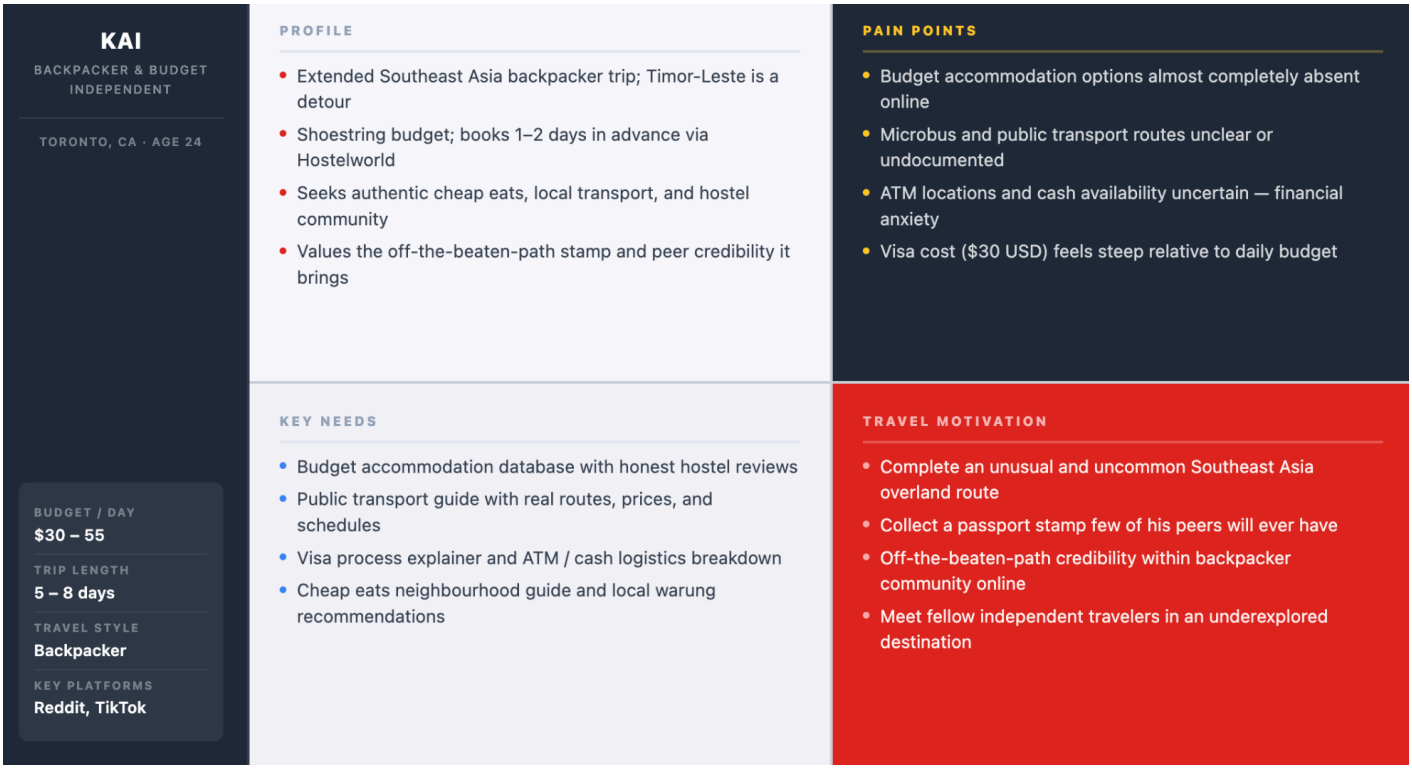
05 · SHARING

Storytelling Reach

Publishes a photography-led travel blog post and Instagram Reels with cultural captions. Contributes a detailed Thorn Tree forum thread. The post receives sustained comments and discussion from other culturally minded travellers.

Persona 4 – Backpackers & Budget-Oriented Travelers

Persona Profile Snapshot



Visitor Journey

